

Art & Design

Year 7

Student Manual



Art & Design

Year 7 · Student Handbook & Workbook

Every child is an artist. Keep the studio open.

Year 7 art and design develops making, looking and thinking: drawing, colour, print, 3D and the artists who changed how we see.

INSIDE THIS BOOK

- Skills: drawing, paint, print, 3D
- Artists and movements in context
- Sketchbook habit and portfolio building
- Critique language and reflection
- Final project per unit

IMPRINT

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Welcome

This book is your student handbook and workbook for Year 7 Art & Design.

You will use it in class to learn, to look, to try ideas, and to keep evidence of your thinking. It is not only a reading book and not only a colouring book. It is both: places to understand ideas, and places to draw, write and reflect.

Path for every topic:

READ → LOOK → THINK → DISCOVER → TRY → CREATE → REFLECT

How artists work

Most artists do not jump straight to a final masterpiece. A common studio cycle is:

1. Notice something (an object, a feeling, another artwork, a place).
2. Collect (sketches, photos, notes, material tests).
3. Try (rough versions, mistakes, surprises).
4. Choose (what to keep, what to change).
5. Refine (improve control, composition, meaning).
6. Share (show, title, explain).
7. Reflect (what did I learn?).

Your sketchbook is where steps 1 to 4 live. Finished pieces are where steps 5 and 6 show. Reflection pages in this book are step 7.

Your sketchbook

Treat your sketchbook as a studio brain, not a neat scrapbook.

Do	Avoid
Date pages	Waiting for a "perfect" first page
Label tests (blind contour, charcoal shell)	Throwing away "ugly" warm-ups
Stick in tickets, textures, photos	Only copying finished internet images
Write short notes in your own words	Copying long biographies

Warm-ups that look wrong can still be excellent practice. Neatness is not the same as learning.

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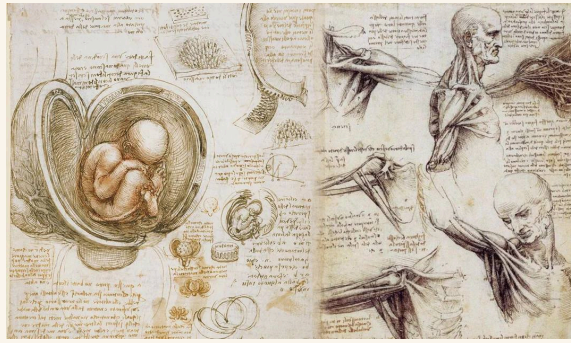


IMAGE 0.00 — Leonardo da Vinci sketchbook pages. Purpose: show that great sketchbooks are exploratory — studies, notes and inventions together, not perfect finished drawings.

Great sketchbooks are rarely “perfect”. They are curious: overlapping studies, quick notes, inventions, mistakes and discoveries on the same page.

What is Art & Design?

Art & Design is a subject about looking, thinking, making and communicating.

When you study Art & Design, you are not simply learning how to draw or paint. You are learning how to observe the world carefully, explore ideas, experiment with materials, solve visual problems and communicate your thoughts through images and objects.

Artists and designers work in many different ways. They may draw, paint, photograph, print, sculpt, build, collage, design objects, create patterns, work digitally or combine several different approaches. There is no single material or technique that defines Art & Design.



IMAGE 0.01 — Ways of making. Purpose: show that Art & Design includes many materials and approaches, not only painting.

Art and Design are connected — but they are not the same

Art often explores ideas, experiences, emotions, questions and ways of seeing the world. An artist might create a painting to communicate a feeling, respond to something happening around them, explore identity, or investigate what can be done with colour, shape or material.

Design usually begins with a purpose or a problem to solve. Designers create things for people to use, understand, experience or interact with. They might design a poster, book cover, chair, building, website, piece of clothing, package or digital interface.

The difference is not always clear. A poster can be both artistic and functional. A photograph can communicate an idea and also advertise something. A piece of furniture can be useful and carefully designed for a visual or emotional experience.

This is why we study Art & Design together.



IMAGE 0.02 — Designed object with purpose. Purpose: introduce design as creative problem-solving with an audience and function.

Did you know?

The word **design** comes from the idea of making a plan or drawing something before it is made. The word **art** has a much older history and has been used to describe human creativity, skill and making across many cultures and periods. There is no single definition of art that everyone agrees on. That is part of what makes it interesting. People have been asking "What is art?" for centuries, and the answer keeps changing.

Art is a way of seeing

One of the most important things you will learn in this course is to look carefully.

We often look at things without really seeing them.

If someone asks you to draw a shoe from memory, you might draw a simple shape with a sole, laces and a few details. But if you place an actual shoe in front of you and observe it carefully, you will notice much more:

- the exact shape of the sole
- the way the material bends
- different textures
- highlights and shadows
- stitching
- reflections
- spaces between the laces
- areas that overlap
- changes in colour
- small imperfections

Observational drawing teaches you to notice these details. The more carefully you look, the more you can see.



IMAGE 0.03 — Memory vs observation. Purpose: compare a simplified memory sketch of a shoe with a careful observational study of the same object.

Think

What is the difference between *looking* and *observing*? Write one sentence.

Art is also a way of thinking

Artists do not simply make something and hope that it works. They make decisions.

They ask questions such as:

- What am I trying to communicate?
- What should the viewer notice first?
- Which materials will work best?
- What colours should I use?
- How should I organise the composition?
- Should the image look realistic or abstract?
- What happens if I change the scale?
- What happens if I remove information?
- How can I make the viewer feel something?

Sometimes the most important part of an artwork is not the final image but the thinking and experimentation that happened before it. This is why your sketchbook is important.

There is no single "right" way to make art

Two students can receive exactly the same task and produce completely different artworks. Both can be successful.

Imagine the task: Create an artwork inspired by nature.

- One student draws a realistic shell.
- Another enlarges the shell until it becomes abstract.
- Another uses the shell as a pattern.
- Another photographs it.
- Another makes a sculpture inspired by its spiral.
- Another uses its colours for an abstract painting.

All of these approaches can be valid. What matters is that you can explain your choices and show how your ideas developed.

Art can take very different forms. Across this book you will meet artists such as Picasso, Matisse, O'Keeffe and Kandinsky — not as a list of famous names to memorise, but as different ways of seeing and making.



IMAGE 0.04 — Many forms of art (teaching panel). Purpose: show that art can be linear, colourful, close-up natural form or abstract — different valid approaches to the same subject idea.

Teacher / pupil note

The first pages of this handbook deliberately focus on ****your**** observation, experimentation and ideas. Finished "masterpieces" come later. Your process is as important as a polished final piece.

Artists experiment

Artists rarely know exactly what the final artwork will look like before they begin.

They test things. They make mistakes. They change their minds. They start again. They combine unexpected materials. Sometimes they discover something interesting because an experiment did not work as planned.

Do not think of mistakes as something that must be hidden. A failed experiment can be useful evidence of learning.

Remember

****Experiment → Observe → Evaluate → Change → Try again****

This process is called ****development****.

IMAGE 0.05 — Process page / sketchbook evidence. Purpose: show that testing, notes and changes are part of professional and student practice.

Art & Design is about process

In this course you will not be assessed only on your final artwork. Your process matters too.

You will learn to:

1. RESEARCH — find information, artists, images and ideas
 2. OBSERVE — look carefully at subjects, artworks and materials
 3. EXPERIMENT — try different techniques and possibilities
 4. DEVELOP — select the strongest ideas and improve them
 5. CREATE — produce a final outcome
 6. REFLECT — evaluate what worked and decide what could improve
- Professional artists and designers use this cycle as well as students.

Creative process



Research → Observe → Experiment → Develop → Create → Reflect

IMAGE 0.06 — Creative process diagram. Purpose: give a clear visual of Research → Observe → Experiment → Develop → Create → Reflect.

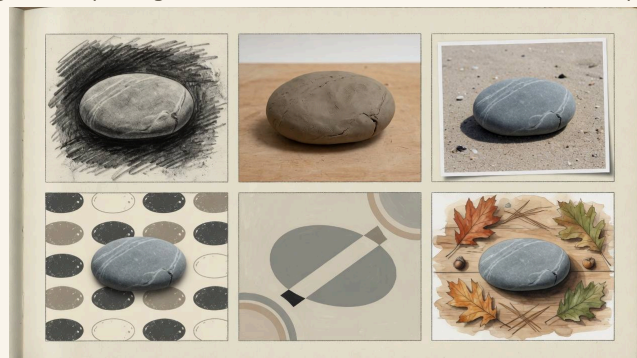


IMAGE 0.07 — One stone, six ways of seeing. Purpose: the same ordinary stone as texture, sculpture, photo, pattern, abstract shape, and still-life element.

Art can communicate without words

Imagine seeing a painting without knowing its title or the artist's name. You may still notice colour, movement, scale, expression, texture, contrast, shapes, light and composition.

These visual elements can communicate ideas and emotions without written language.

- Dark colours, strong contrasts and dramatic diagonal lines can create tension.
- Pale colours, soft edges and horizontal lines can create calm.

This is called visual language. It is one of the central ideas of this course.

Artists see the world differently

Artists do not necessarily see more than everyone else. They often choose to look differently. They notice something ordinary and transform it.

A stone can become: a study of texture · a sculptural form · a photograph · a pattern · an abstract shape · part of a larger composition.

Panel	What the artist did
Texture	Surface marks, cracks and grain
Sculpture	Rebuilt the form in clay / 3D
Photograph	Framed it as the subject
Pattern	Repeated the silhouette
Abstract	Simplified into geometric planes
Composition	Placed it in a still life

A shadow can become the subject of a photograph. A collection of objects can become a still life. A simple colour combination can become an abstract painting.

Art can change the way we see familiar things.

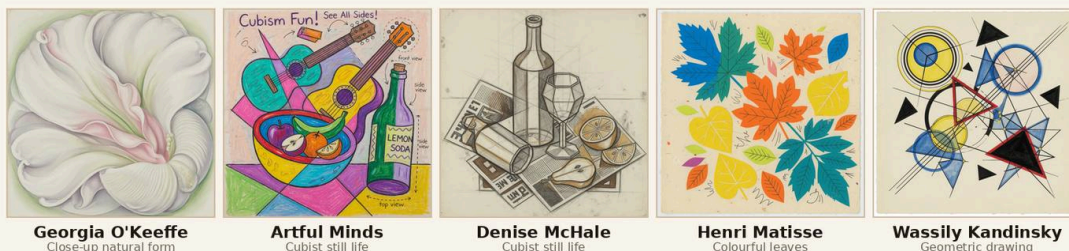


IMAGE 0.08 — Five ways of seeing. Purpose: compare how different artists transform familiar subjects — close-up nature, Cubist still life, colourful leaves, and geometric abstraction. Teaching illustrations inspired by each approach (not museum reproductions).

Artist / source	What to notice
Georgia O'Keeffe	Close-up natural form; familiar things become huge and intimate
Artful Minds	Cubist still life; playful multi-viewpoint classroom Cubism
Denise McHale	Cubist still life; fragmented planes and overlapping viewpoints
Henri Matisse	Colourful leaves; bold flat colour and decorative shape
Wassily Kandinsky	Geometric drawing; circles, lines and shapes as visual music

Looking at artists

These panels are **teaching illustrations** made for this handbook to show each approach. Famous museum paintings may still be in copyright, so we study the **idea** here and look at licensed images with your teacher when needed.

Design starts with a purpose

Designers also make visual decisions, but they usually have a particular purpose or audience.

Imagine you design a poster for a school art exhibition. You need to think about:

- Who will see it?
- What information must be included?
- Which words are most important?
- How large should the title be?
- Which colours will attract attention?
- Can people understand it quickly?
- Where should images and text be placed?

A beautiful poster that nobody can read is not necessarily a successful design. Design involves creative problem-solving.

Art & Design in everyday life

You encounter Art & Design every day, even outside the art room. Someone designed:

your chair · school uniform · phone · food packaging · school signs · books · websites and apps · buildings · public spaces · advertisements · photographs · films and animations.

Art and design influence how the world looks, feels and functions.

Studio expectations, health and safety

Expectation	Why
Arrive ready (sketchbook, pencils)	So making can start quickly
Start within two minutes of the brief	Protects making time
Share materials; return them clean	Fair studio for everyone
Talk about work with respect	Notice first; judge carefully
Leave the table cleaner than you found it	Professional habit

Health & Safety

Walk with scissors pointed down. Do not blow charcoal or pastel dust toward faces; tap into a bin. Cap ink and wipe spills. Tie long hair back for printmaking or clay. Tell the teacher about allergies. Wash hands before touching books, phones or food.

Looking after materials

Material	Care
Pencils	Do not stab erasers; sharpen over a bin
Charcoal	Store dry; fix finished work if told to
Ink / fine liners	Recap; do not pump liners on the page
Paper	Keep a clean "best sheet" separate from tests
Viewfinder / ruler	Return to the shared kit

How to record your work

For each important task, record:

1. Title and date
2. Media (pencil, charcoal, ink...)
3. Intention (one sentence)
4. Process evidence (thumbnail, test, photo)
5. Final (mounted, photographed, or drawn in the book)
6. Reflection (what changed)

Teachers assess process as well as product. A strong sketchbook can matter as much as one polished page.

How to reflect

Use sentence stems until reflection feels natural:

- I noticed...
- I changed... because...
- The visual element I used most clearly was...
- If I had one more hour I would...
- Next time I will practise...

Honest reflection is a skill, not a punishment.

Think like an artist

When you look at something, try asking:

Step	Question
LOOK	What can I actually see?
NOTICE	What details stand out?
QUESTION	Why might it look this way?
EXPERIMENT	What would happen if I changed something?
CONNECT	Does this remind me of another artist, object, place or idea?
CREATE	How could I use this observation in my own work?

Try it — looking differently

Choose an ordinary object from the classroom (pencil, chair, scissors, water bottle, shoe, plant).

1. Look at it for two full minutes without drawing.
2. Write down ten things you notice.
3. Do not write only "It is a chair." Write observations such as:
- "The back is slightly curved." - "There is a dark triangular space underneath." - "The light catches the edge of the metal." - "One leg looks darker because it faces away from the window."
4. Make a quick drawing of the object.
5. Compare: How is your drawing different from the picture you had in your head before you observed?

Your turn — ten observations

Object:

- 1.
- 2.
- 3.
- 4.
- 5.
- 6.
- 7.
- 8.
- 9.
- 10.

What changed after careful looking?

quick observational drawing

Your first Art & Design challenge

Create a small artwork called "LOOK AGAIN".

Choose something ordinary that you normally ignore. Draw, photograph, paint or collage it so the viewer looks at it differently.

You must change at least one of these: scale · viewpoint · colour · cropping · repetition · texture · context.

Big challenge — LOOK AGAIN

What was ordinary about your subject?

What did you change?

How does your artwork make the viewer see it differently?

LOOK AGAIN — final / attach work

Key vocabulary

Word	Meaning here
Art	Creative practice used to explore, communicate or express ideas, experiences and ways of seeing
Design	Creative problem-solving with a purpose, audience or function
Visual language	The way visual elements communicate ideas and meaning
Observation	Careful looking in order to notice and record information
Experiment	Trying a material, technique or idea to discover what happens
Process	The sequence of actions and decisions involved in making an artwork
Development	Changing, improving and extending ideas through experimentation
Composition	The way visual elements are organised within an artwork
Audience	The people who view, use or experience an artwork or design
Context	The circumstances surrounding an artwork, including time, place, culture and ideas

Reflect

Complete these sentences in your sketchbook:

- Before this lesson, I thought Art & Design was...
- Now I think Art & Design is...
- One thing artists do that I had not considered before is...
- Something I would like to learn how to do this year is...
- An artist is successful when...

Your turn — reflect

Before this lesson, I thought Art & Design was...

Now I think Art & Design is...

One thing artists do that I had not considered...

Something I want to learn this year...

An artist is successful when...

How to use this book (reminder)

Step	What you do
READ	short teaching in clear language
LOOK	study an image labelled IMAGE ... and its purpose
THINK	answer a small question before making
DISCOVER	a verified curiosity or artist link
TRY	a short practical exercise
CREATE	a fuller making task
REFLECT	checklist or written evaluation

Unit 7.1 - Drawing

On the drawing desk today

A soft yellow pencil lies on cream paper beside a shell, a strip of bark and a stone.
Your teacher says: "Before colour projects and artist presentations, we draw. Drawing is the skeleton of the year."
Open this unit with curiosity, not fear of neatness. Many of the best practice pages look strange on purpose.

IMAGE 7.1.01 — Drawing desk with natural forms and geometric planes. Purpose: show the Unit 7.1 studio setup and the objects you will observe.

Studio kit

Keep ready	Why
HB, 2B, 4B pencils	map, mid-tone, dark tone
charcoal	soft tonal drawing
fine liner / pen and ink	mark-making
eraser and putty rubber	lift lights; correct carefully
sketchbook + cartridge paper	tests and finals
viewfinder	crop compositions

Studio safety

Do not blow charcoal dust toward anyone. Tap the page over a bin. Cap ink. Protect tables. Wash hands before touching shared books.

[7.1.1] Introduction to visual elements

Open the door

If you had only six words to describe a drawing, which six would you choose?

The visual elements (also called formal elements) are the shared toolkit of art and design: line, shape, form, texture, colour, composition (with tone and space working inside them). This topic studies each one, then joins them in one activity.

Clear diagrams help you recognise each element quickly — the same way art institutes teach the building blocks of drawing and painting.

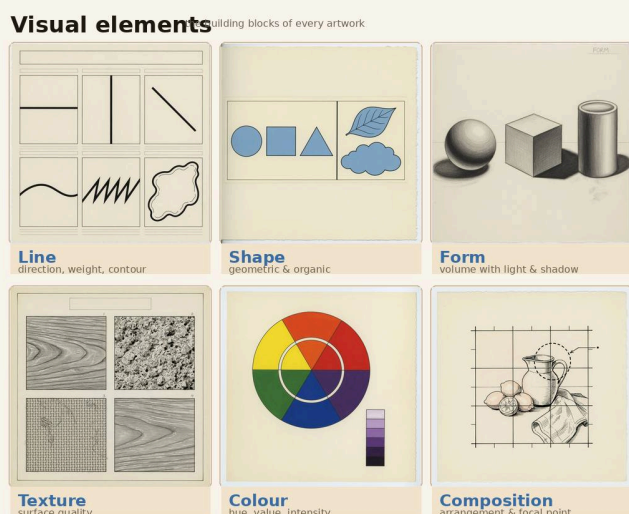


IMAGE 7.1.02 — Visual elements board. Purpose: clear teaching diagrams for Line, Shape, Form, Texture, Colour and Composition (art-institute style overview).

Line

Definition: a mark with length and direction. Line can describe edges, build tone, show movement, or express feeling.

Idea	What it means	Try this
types of line	straight, curved, broken, implied	draw five line types in a row
line weight	thick / thin; pressure changes meaning	one object, three weights
contour	edge-line of a form	slow contour of a shoe
expressive line	line that shows mood	angry / calm versions of the same cup
gesture	fast line that catches action or energy	20-second whole-object sweep
line and movement	direction leads the eye	lines that spiral into a focal point
line and texture	repeated lines suggest surface	short ticks for bark

Artists using line (study set): Pablo Picasso (continuous-line drawings), Henri Matisse (contour drawings), Vincent van Gogh (energetic reed-pen lines), Bridget Riley (line used for optical movement).

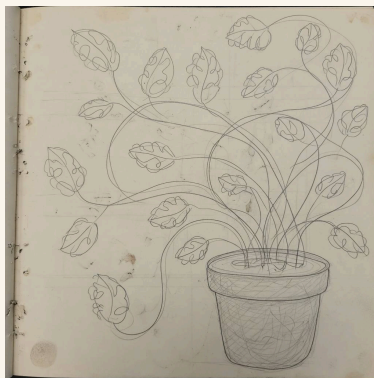


IMAGE 7.1.03 — Continuous-line study. Purpose: show how a single unbroken line can describe a form with minimal detail (classroom example).

Did you know?

Matisse sometimes drew with a long stick of charcoal so his whole arm moved, not only his fingers. Bigger movement often makes clearer contours.

Your turn — line

1. Define **contour** in your own words.

2. Draw the same key three times: thin contour, thick expressive line, fast gesture.

Observation question: Where does the line get darker on a real object under side light?

Answer:

thin contour

expressive weight

20-second gesture

which taught me most?

Challenge — line

Make a one-minute continuous-line drawing of your non-drawing hand without lifting the pen. Title it. Reflect: what detail appeared that you usually skip?

Line vocabulary: contour · line weight · gesture · implied line · expressive line

Shape

A shape is a two-dimensional area enclosed by a boundary. Shapes have height and width, but they do not have physical depth.

Shapes can be geometric (circle, square, triangle) or organic (leaf, puddle, cloud). Artists can combine geometric and organic shapes to create different visual effects.

Idea	What it means
positive shape	the subject itself
negative shape	the surrounding space around / between subjects
shape vs form	shape is flat; form suggests volume
silhouette	a solid outline shape, usually dark on light
simplification	reducing a complex object to basic shapes first

Shape and simplification

Artists often simplify complicated objects into basic shapes. This does not mean the final artwork has to look geometric. The simplified shapes are a way of understanding and constructing what we see.

- A human head can initially be understood as an oval.
- A bottle might begin as rectangles, cylinders and curves.
- A house might be reduced to squares, rectangles and triangles.

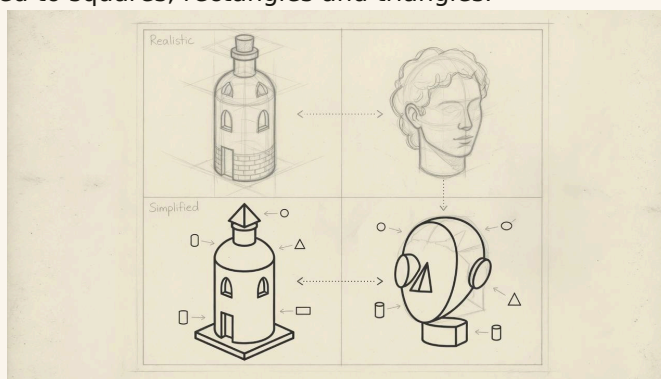


IMAGE 7.1.03b — Shape and simplification. Purpose: show realistic subjects reduced to basic geometric construction shapes.

Shape and silhouette

A silhouette is a simplified shape showing the outline of a subject, usually as a solid dark area against a lighter background. Silhouettes remove unnecessary detail. If you can recognise an object from its silhouette, you understand something important about its shape.



IMAGE 7.1.03c — Silhouettes. Purpose: show that outline alone can identify a subject.

Artists: Matisse (paper cut-outs as pure shape), Islamic geometric designers, logo designers who rely on silhouette clarity.

Your turn — Shape Hunt

Look around the classroom. Find **5 geometric shapes** and **5 organic shapes**. Draw each one in your sketchbook. Then choose one object and reduce it to **five simple shapes or fewer**.

5 geometric + 5 organic

one object → five shapes or fewer

Your turn — shape studies

Draw one bottle as: (1) silhouette only, (2) geometric simplification, (3) organic outline with no inner detail.

silhouette

geometric simplification

organic outline

Shape vocabulary: geometric · organic · silhouette · positive shape · negative shape · simplification

Form

Form refers to something that has three dimensions: height, width and depth.

Shape (2D)	Form (3D / illusion of 3D)
circle	sphere
square	cube
rectangle	cuboid
triangle	cone / pyramid

A drawing is two-dimensional, but an artist can create the illusion of form by using light, shadow, tone, perspective and overlapping shapes.

Creating the illusion of form

Imagine a simple circle. On its own, it looks flat. Now imagine a gradual change from light to dark across the circle, with a highlight on one side and a shadow on the other. The circle begins to look like a sphere. Artists use this principle constantly.

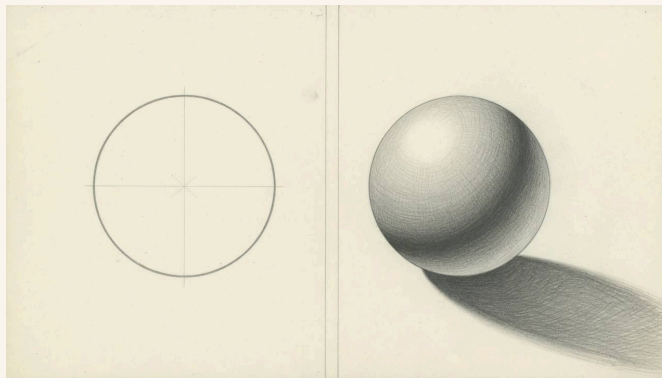


IMAGE 7.1.03d — Shape into form. Purpose: show a flat circle becoming a sphere through highlight, mid-tone, core shadow and cast shadow.

Light and shadow

When light hits a three-dimensional object, different areas receive different amounts of light:

Tone word	Meaning
highlight	the lightest area
light	an area receiving direct or strong light
mid-tone	between light and dark
core shadow	one of the darkest areas on the form itself
cast shadow	the shadow the object throws onto another surface
reflected light	faint light bouncing back into shadow

Learning to see these differences is essential for realistic drawing.

Your turn — Turn shape into form

Draw: circle → sphere · square → cube · rectangle → cuboid · triangle → cone. Use only pencil and tone. Do not outline every part equally.

Think: Which areas need to be darkest? Where is the lightest area? Where does the cast shadow fall?

circle→sphere · square→cube · rectangle→cuboid · triangle→cone

Form vocabulary: volume · modelling · highlight · mid-tone · core shadow · cast shadow

Texture

Texture describes the surface quality of something. It can be actual or visual.

Type	Meaning	Example
actual (tactile)	you can physically feel it	rough bark, smooth glass, soft fabric
visual (implied)	an illusion made with marks	a drawing of fur that looks furry

Texture vocabulary

rough · smooth · soft · hard · shiny · matt · grainy · cracked · ridged · furry · woven · slippery · bumpy · scaly

Texture through mark-making

Artists create visual texture by changing their marks:

- Dots → sand or small stones
- Short irregular lines → bark
- Long flowing lines → hair or grass
- Cross-hatching → roughness and shadow
- Smooth tonal transitions → polished surfaces

The marks must relate to the surface you are trying to describe — not simply add lots of detail.

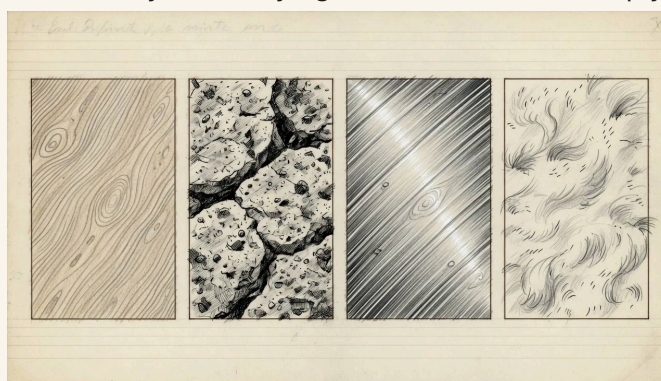


IMAGE 7.1.03e — Texture library samples. Purpose: show different mark systems that suggest wood, stone, metal and fur.

Look at art: Käthe Kollwitz

Käthe Kollwitz used drawing and printmaking marks to create powerful images of people. Look at the density, direction and weight of her marks.

Ask: Where are the darkest areas? Where are marks most concentrated? Are they smooth or rough? How do the marks contribute to the emotional quality of the image?

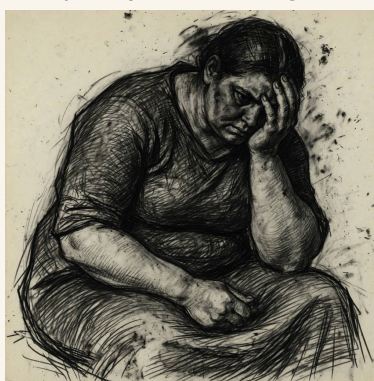


IMAGE 7.1.03f — Mark density study (teaching illustration after Kollwitz). Purpose: show how dense, directional marks create texture and emotion. Not a museum reproduction.

Your turn — Texture Library

Create a grid of **12 squares**. Make each square a different texture (wood, stone, glass, metal, fabric, fur, water, bark, sand, leaves, feathers, free choice). Do **not** write the name inside the square. Ask a partner to guess the materials.

12-square texture library

Texture vocabulary: actual texture · visual texture · frottage · mark-making · matt · grainy

Colour (as a visual element in drawing)

Colour is one of the most powerful visual elements. Artists use it to describe objects, create contrast, establish mood, attract attention, create depth, organise a composition, communicate symbolism, express emotions and create harmony.

Three important properties:

Word	Meaning
hue	the basic colour family (red, blue, yellow...)
value	how light or dark a colour is
saturation	how intense or muted a colour appears

Colour is explored in much greater detail in Unit 7.2 — Colour. Here, use colour as a drawing support (for example one accent).

Look at art: Wassily Kandinsky

Kandinsky was interested in relationships between colour, shape and emotion. In his abstract paintings, colours do not necessarily represent real-world objects. A blue shape does not have to be "a blue object" — colour becomes part of the visual language.

Think

If you had to represent **anger** using only colour, what would you choose? What about **peace**? Would everyone make the same choice?

Your turn — colour in drawing

Make a small tonal study in graphite, then add **one** accent colour only where it helps the focal point.

Composition

Composition is the way visual elements are arranged within an artwork.

Imagine the same five objects arranged in five different ways. The objects have not changed. The composition has — and therefore the artwork feels different.

Artists decide about: position · size · scale · balance · cropping · overlap · repetition · empty space · focal point · contrast.

Focal point

The focal point attracts the viewer's attention. Create it with contrast, colour, detail, scale, sharp edges, unusual placement or light. It does not always have to be in the centre — off-centre placement can be more interesting.

Balance

A composition can feel balanced even when it is not symmetrical.

- Symmetrical balance — elements mirrored or evenly distributed
- Asymmetrical balance — different visual "weights" that still feel stable (for example a large dark object balanced by several smaller lighter ones)

Cropping

Cropping means deciding which parts are inside the frame and which are outside. It can make a composition more dramatic, intimate, abstract or dynamic.

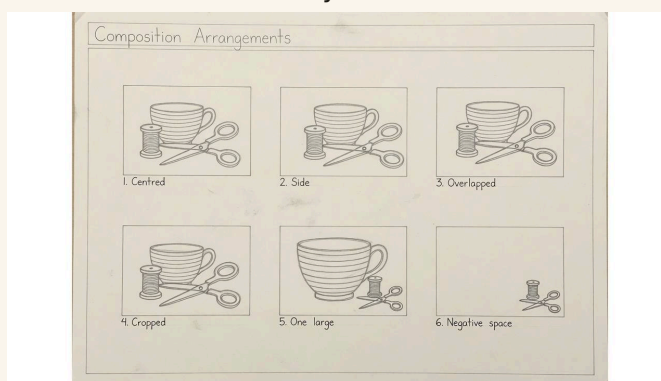


IMAGE 7.1.03g — Six compositions. Purpose: show six different decisions with the same three objects.

Your turn — Six compositions

Arrange three objects on a table. Make **six** small thumbnail drawings. In each one, change something: centre them · move them to one side · overlap · crop one object · make one much larger · leave a large amount of negative space. No more than two minutes each. The purpose is six different **decisions**, not six beautiful drawings.

six thumbnails — different decisions

Composition vocabulary: balance · crop · focal point · hierarchy · viewfinder · symmetrical · asymmetrical

Putting the visual elements together

Artists rarely use visual elements separately. A single artwork might use:

- LINE to describe the edge
- SHAPE to organise the forms
- FORM to create depth
- TEXTURE to describe surfaces
- COLOUR to create mood
- COMPOSITION to organise everything

The elements work together.

Final challenge — The Six Elements

Choose one ordinary object. Create six small studies:

1. **LINE** — different types of line
2. **SHAPE** — reduce to simple shapes
3. **FORM** — tone for three dimensions
4. **TEXTURE** — concentrate on surface
5. **COLOUR** — change appearance or mood
6. **COMPOSITION** — change position, scale or surrounding space

Then choose your strongest study.

Final question: Which visual element changed the object most dramatically? Why?

[7.1.2] Warm-up drawing activities

Warm-ups train observation rather than neatness. They often look "wrong" on purpose.

Warm-up examples — real classroom studies

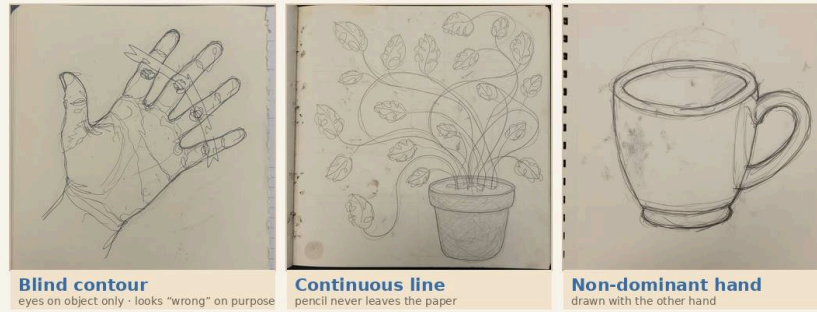


IMAGE 7.1.04 — Warm-up examples (real classroom-style studies). Purpose: match each method clearly — Blind contour (wonky hand), Continuous line (unbroken plant), Non-dominant hand (shaky cup).

Blind contour drawing

Eyes on the object only. Pencil follows edges. No peeking. 60–90 seconds.

Purpose: slow looking; hand-eye link.

Continuous-line drawing

Pencil never leaves the paper. 1–2 minutes.

Purpose: fluency; connections between parts.

Non-dominant-hand drawing

Draw with your other hand.

Purpose: slow down control-panic; notice shape honestly.

Gesture drawing

Very fast whole-object energy lines (10–30 seconds). Capture movement or mass, not detail.

Purpose: see big relationships first.

Timed drawing

Same object in 30 seconds, 2 minutes, then 10 minutes.

Purpose: learn what time buys you (structure vs detail).

Drawing without erasing

No eraser for five minutes. Wrong lines stay as evidence; correct beside them.

Purpose: commit; observe instead of polishing too early.

Did you know?

Art educator Kimon Nicolaïdes popularised contour practice in **The Natural Way to Draw** (1941), arguing that eye and hand must train together slowly, like musicians.

Your turn — warm-up circuit

Complete the circuit. Date the page *Warm-up circuit*.

| Warm-up | Time | Done |

|---|---|---|

| blind contour (hand) | 90 s | ☐ |

| continuous line (bag/plant) | 2 min | ☐ |

| non-dominant hand (cup) | 2 min | ☐ |

| gesture (classmate pose or chair) | 30 s × 3 | ☐ |

| timed set (same object) | 30 s / 2 / 10 | ☐ |

| no-eraser study | 5 min | ☐ |

What detail did warm-ups reveal that "careful drawing" usually misses?

Go a bit further

Second study of the ****same**** object from the opposite side. One sentence: what changed?

[7.1.3] Natural forms and observation

Observational drawing means drawing from the real thing in front of you. Natural forms (shells, bark, stones, leaves) are excellent teachers because their surfaces change slowly and force you to use tone.



IMAGE 7.1.05 — Shell, bark and stone with tonal study. Purpose: model observational looking and charcoal/pencil tone from natural forms.

Looking before drawing

Progression for this topic:

observe → map → tone → darks → lights → texture

Step	Action
observe	walk around; choose a viewpoint; notice light direction
map	light gesture of big proportions and edges
tone	block mid-values; squint to simplify
darks	push core shadows and deep gaps
lights	leave paper white or lift with putty rubber
texture	add marks only where the surface needs them

Edges: hard edges where form turns sharply; soft edges where form turns gently.
Charcoal tips: work from mid to dark; use putty rubber as a drawing tool to pull highlights, not only to delete mistakes.
Artists: observational natural-form traditions in student academies; Van Gogh's studies of nature for energetic surface; contemporary charcoal still-life artists your teacher may show.

Your turn — charcoal natural form

- 20–30 minute study of one shell, stone or bark piece under side light.
- Light from (circle): left / right / above
- Media: pencil / charcoal / both
- Proportion check: what is the widest measurement compared with the tallest?

natural form tonal study

[7.1.4] Mark-making exploration

Mark-making is your drawing vocabulary.

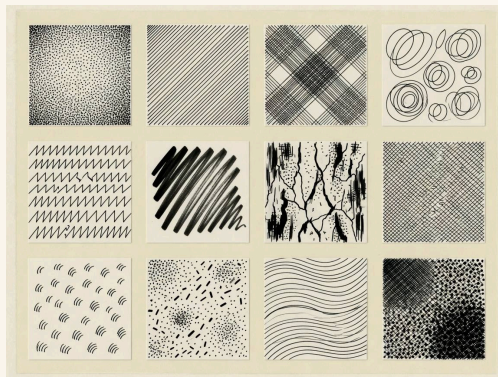


IMAGE 7.1.06 — Pen-and-ink mark chart. Purpose: provide a visual library of marks before applying them to objects.

Visual library (learn and label)

hatching · cross-hatching · stippling · scumbling · scribbling · contour hatching · dots · dashes · directional marks · broken marks · layered marks · varied pressure

Texture through mark-making

Choose marks that fit what you see: short vertical broken marks for bark; soft stipple for a matte stone; long directional strokes for brushed metal.

Artists and mark-making

Van Gogh (directional energy), Kollwitz (dense dark networks), pen-and-ink illustrators who build tone without a single filled black shape.

Did you know?

Hatching and cross-hatching let artists create many tones with one dark ink. In old master drawings and prints, darkness is often layered marks, not a flat fill.

Your turn — 12-mark exercise then object study

1. Fill a **12-box mark chart**. Label each box with a verb (*stab, drag, tick, swirl*).
2. Pick three marks and make a small natural-object study using only those marks.

12-box mark chart

natural-object study from three marks

[7.1.5] Positive and negative space

Positive space = area of the subject. Negative space = shapes of the air around and between subjects.
Figure/ground = how subject and background swap importance.



IMAGE 7.1.07 — Jug and cup with shaded gaps. Purpose: show negative space as solid puzzle shapes that improve proportion.

Also study: cropping, overlap, enclosed spaces (handle holes), and balance between busy and quiet areas.

Did you know?

Edgar Rubin's vase (1915) can be read as a vase **or** two facing profiles. Designers still use figure/ground flips so logos hide a second meaning in the gap.

Your turn

Left: draw objects normally. Right: shade **only** negative spaces.

positive first

[7.1.6] Multi-viewpoint drawing

A single camera angle is only one way to know an object. Multi-viewpoint drawing shows front, side and above in one image.



IMAGE 7.1.08 — Multi-viewpoint jug study. Purpose: demonstrate overlapping viewpoints and geometric planes as a Cubist classroom method.

Introduction to Cubism

Early twentieth-century artists Pablo Picasso and Georges Braque helped develop Cubism, often showing several angles of one subject together. Analytical Cubism (about 1909–1912) often used a limited brown-grey palette so structure stayed clear.

In class you will not copy a museum painting. You will use the idea: build one image with two or three viewpoints overlapped as planes.

Copyright note

Many Cubist museum paintings remain in copyright in Europe. We study the idea with original classroom work and teacher-selected licensed images.

Your turn — Cubist still-life construction

One object. Overlay front + above (+ optional side) on a single page. Separate planes with 2–3 tones.

Object:

Viewpoints:

[7.1.7] Personal still-life project

This is a full project, not a quick sketch.

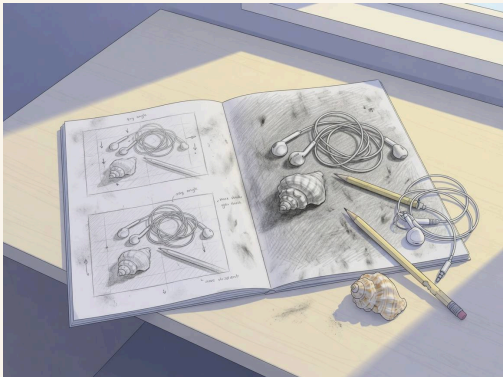


IMAGE 7.1.09 — Personal still-life process. Purpose: show thumbnails beside a finished tonal still life as decision tools, not decoration.

Project brief

Part	Requirement
aim	a personal still life that shows observation + chosen visual elements
objects	3-5 items with a clear theme (morning, music, beach walk, my tools...)
arrangement	intentional gaps; stable lighting
thumbnails	at least two small composition plans before the large drawing
underdrawing	light map of proportions
development	tone and/or mark-making; optional multi-viewpoint twist
refinement	adjust edges, hierarchy, quiet areas
presentation	title + one process sentence

Thumbnails are decision tools, not "three tiny obligatory drawings". Use them to choose crop, balance and focal point.

Assessment checklist

- ☐ Theme and objects chosen with a reason
- ☐ Two thumbnails compared; one selected on purpose
- ☐ Observation from life (not only from a phone photo)
- ☐ At least three clear tones
- ☐ Negative space considered
- ☐ Marks/texture used where useful
- ☐ Title and short process note
- ☐ Sketchbook evidence kept (tests, warm-up, photos)

Big challenge

Complete the final still life on good paper. Keep thumbnails and one test as evidence.

Theme:

Title:

Process sentence:

thumbnail B

final still life / attach work

[7.1.8] Review and reflection

Self-assessment

What worked: _____ What failed / struggled: _____ What changed during the work: _____
Next steps: _____

Peer assessment (partner writes)

I notice... _____ One question I have is... _____ One strength is... _____

Presentation

Be ready to show: one warm-up, one observational study, final still life. Speak for about one minute using art vocabulary.

What have I learned?

I can...

- ☐ use different types of line and line weight
- ☐ explain shape vs form
- ☐ model basic form with light and shadow
- ☐ describe actual and visual texture
- ☐ use colour as a simple accent or value idea in drawing
- ☐ choose a composition on purpose (crop, balance, focal point)
- ☐ complete observation warm-ups (including gesture, timed, no-eraser)
- ☐ make a tonal study from a natural form
- ☐ build and apply a mark-making library
- ☐ explain positive and negative space / figure-ground
- ☐ construct a multi-viewpoint (Cubist-idea) study
- ☐ plan and finish a personal still-life project
- ☐ reflect and set a next-step target

Key words

visual elements · line · line weight · contour · gesture · shape · geometric · organic · silhouette · form · volume · tone · highlight · cast shadow · texture · actual texture · visual texture · hue · value · saturation · composition · focal point · viewfinder · blind contour · continuous line · observation · natural form · charcoal · hatching · cross-hatching · stippling · scumbling · positive space · negative space · figure/ground · viewpoint · Cubism · still life · thumbnail

Artists to remember

Picasso · Braque · Matisse · Van Gogh · Bridget Riley · Max Ernst · Käthe Kollwitz (Unit 7.2 will add Matisse, Van Gogh, Kandinsky, Rothko, O'Keeffe for colour mood.)

My best work

glue / draw / photograph your strongest Unit 7.1 piece

My reflection

The most important thing I learned was... _____

The skill I improved most was... _____

The thing I still need to practise is... _____

By the end of Unit 7.1 you can

- + Name and use the visual elements in drawing tasks.
- + Train looking with a full warm-up circuit.
- + Observe natural forms with a clear tonal method.
- + Invent marks and apply them to texture.
- + Use negative space and multi-viewpoint ideas.
- + Deliver and evaluate a personal still life.

Unit 7.2 - Colour

Unit 7.2 — Colour

Colour is one of the most powerful visual elements in Art & Design.

Artists use colour to describe, organise, emphasise, communicate and express. Colour can make an object appear realistic, but it can also change reality completely. A blue face, a purple tree or a red sky may not be realistic, but they can communicate an idea, feeling or atmosphere.

Colour can make an artwork feel: calm or energetic · warm or cold · happy or sad · peaceful or dramatic · natural or artificial · harmonious or uncomfortable.

However, colour does not have one fixed meaning. The way we understand a colour can depend on context, culture, surrounding colours and our own experiences.

In this unit you will learn how colours are organised, how they interact and how artists use them deliberately.

Looking at artists

Artist images in this unit are **teaching illustrations** inspired by each artist's approach (not museum reproductions). Famous paintings may still be in copyright; study licensed images with your teacher when needed.

[7.2.1] Introduction to colour theory

What is colour?

Colour is the visual sensation produced when light reaches our eyes. The colours we see depend on the light that falls on objects and the wavelengths reflected towards our eyes.

For an artist working with paint, colour is also a material that can be mixed, layered and changed. Colour theory helps us understand relationships between colours and make more informed choices.

The colour wheel

A colour wheel is a visual diagram showing relationships between colours. The traditional painting colour wheel usually begins with three primary colours:

RED · YELLOW · BLUE

From these, artists mix secondary and tertiary colours.



IMAGE 7.2.01 — RYB colour wheel. Purpose: show primary, secondary and tertiary relationships for paint mixing.

Primary colours

In traditional paint-based colour theory, the primary colours are red, yellow and blue. They are taught as colours that cannot be created by mixing the other colours on the same paint system. They are the starting point for our colour-mixing exercises.

Your turn — primaries

Paint three circles: red, yellow, blue. Do not mix them yet. Which colour feels strongest? Why? There is no single correct answer.

red · yellow · blue circles

Secondary colours

Secondary colours are made by mixing two primary colours:

Mix	Result
red + yellow	orange
yellow + blue	green
blue + red	violet

The result depends on the exact pigments and proportions. Adding slightly more yellow to a red-and-yellow mixture can create a yellow-orange rather than a balanced orange.



IMAGE 7.2.02 — Paint mixing. Purpose: show primary pairs mixing into secondary colours on a palette.

Your turn — secondaries

Mix red+yellow, yellow+blue, blue+red. Paint each mixture. Then make a second version of each by changing the proportions.

secondary mixes + proportion variants

Think

Do you get exactly the same orange from more red + a little yellow, and a little red + more yellow? Why not?

Tertiary colours

Tertiary colours are created by mixing a primary colour with a neighbouring secondary colour. Examples: yellow-orange · red-orange · red-violet · blue-violet · blue-green · yellow-green. These create a much larger range than the basic six colours.

Your turn — 12-part colour wheel

Create a 12-part colour wheel. Label primary, secondary and tertiary colours. Try to mix each colour rather than using a colour straight from the tube.

12-part colour wheel

Hue, value and saturation

Term	Meaning	Example
hue	the basic colour family	"a blue hue"
value	how light or dark a colour is	pale blue vs dark blue
saturation	how intense or muted a colour appears	vivid red vs dusty muted red

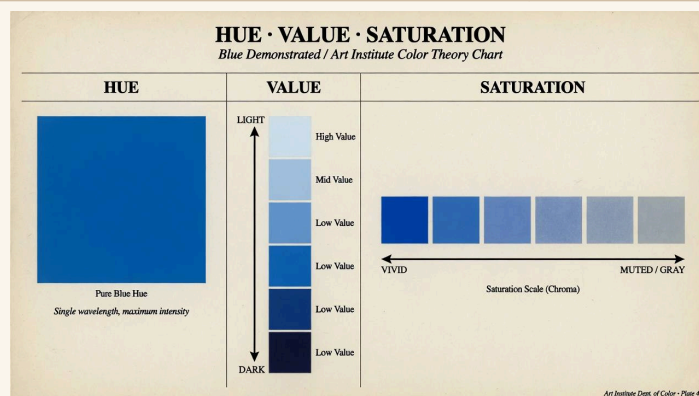


IMAGE 7.2.03 — Hue, value, saturation. Purpose: separate the three properties of colour visually.

Think

Look at a red object. Can you make it lighter without changing its basic hue? Darker? Less saturated? More saturated? How might an artist do this?

Did you know?

Colours on a computer or phone screen are produced differently from paint. Screens use light (often RGB: red, green, blue). Artists working with paint deal with pigments and reflected light. That is one reason a screen colour may not match paint exactly.

[7.2.2] Artists and colour mood

Colour is not only about mixing the "correct" colour. Artists can use colour to create an emotional or psychological response.

Imagine two paintings of exactly the same landscape. One uses soft blues + pale greens + muted violets. The other uses bright oranges + intense reds + strong yellows. Even with identical composition, the two paintings may feel completely different.

Warm colours

Warm colours are generally associated with red · orange · yellow. They can suggest heat, sunlight, energy, excitement, danger, movement, intensity. Context matters — warm colours do not always communicate happiness.

Cool colours

Cool colours are generally associated with blue · green · violet. They can suggest water, distance, calm, quiet, night, cold, melancholy. Again, these associations are not universal.

Look at art: Vincent van Gogh

Van Gogh used colour expressively rather than simply reproducing what he saw. Look at the relationship between blue and yellow in works such as *The Starry Night*. Contrast makes yellow areas appear particularly bright. Van Gogh often placed strong colours next to each other to increase visual intensity.



IMAGE 7.2.04 — Teaching study after Van Gogh. Purpose: show expressive blue/yellow complementary contrast and movement. Not a museum reproduction.

Look closely

Which colours do you notice first? Where are the warm colours? Cool colours? Are they realistic? How does colour contribute to mood?

Look at art: Henri Matisse

Matisse is famous for bold colour. In some paintings, colour does not simply describe the real world — a wall may become intensely red; a landscape may contain colours that never appear that way in nature. Matisse used colour to create harmony, rhythm, contrast and energy.



IMAGE 7.2.05 — Teaching study after Matisse. Purpose: show non-naturalistic intense colour creating harmony and energy. Not a museum reproduction.

Think

Does a colour have to be realistic to be convincing?

Look at art: Wassily Kandinsky

Kandinsky explored relationships between colour, shape and emotion. His abstract paintings do not necessarily show recognisable objects. Colour and shape become the subject. Colour does not always have to describe something — it can be the subject itself.



IMAGE 7.2.06 — Teaching study after Kandinsky. Purpose: show colour and shape as subject in abstraction. Not a museum reproduction.

Colour and emotion

There are no universal rules saying red always means anger or blue always means sadness. Colour meanings depend on context.

Red might suggest: love · danger · anger · celebration · power · heat. Blue might suggest: calm · sadness · trust · cold · distance · spirituality.

Surrounding colours also affect how we perceive a colour.

Think

If you see a bright red square surrounded by black, does it feel different from the same red square surrounded by pale pink? Why?



IMAGE 7.2.07 — One subject, two moods. Purpose: show how palette alone can change calm vs energy.

Task — One subject, two moods

Choose a simple subject (flower, cup, face, landscape, still life). Create two small paintings of exactly the same subject.

****Painting A:**** communicate ****CALM****.

****Painting B:**** communicate ****ENERGY****.

Keep the subject and basic composition similar; change the colours.

Reflect: Which colour choices created the biggest difference?

Painting A — CALM

Painting B — ENERGY

[7.2.3] Primary colour tonal studies

Understanding colour also means understanding light and dark. A colour can exist across a range of values: dark blue → medium blue → light blue. This is a tonal scale.

Term	How it is made	Effect
tint	add white to a colour	lighter
shade	make a colour darker (often with black, or richer darks)	darker
tone	a variation in lightness, darkness or intensity	value/intensity change

Artists do not always need black to darken a colour. Mixing another colour can produce a richer dark. Mixing complementary colours can reduce intensity and create complex dark neutrals.

Practical task — primary colour scales

Create three tonal scales (at least five steps each): RED light→dark · YELLOW light→dark · BLUE light→dark. Make transitions gradual.

three primary tonal scales (5+ steps each)

Challenge

Create a darker version of blue without using only black. Try blue + a little violet, or blue + a little of its complementary. Which dark looks richer?

[7.2.4] Secondary colour mixing

Mixing colours is not simply knowing a formula — it is observation and proportion. If you mix red and yellow equally, you might get orange. But 3 parts yellow + 1 part red gives a more yellow-orange; 3 parts red + 1 part yellow gives a more red-orange. One pair of primaries can produce many results.

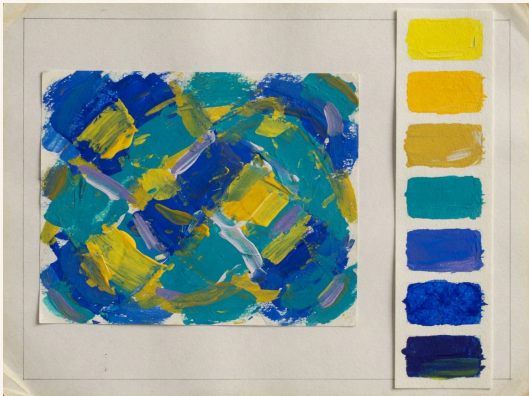


IMAGE 7.2.09 — Student colour-mixing studies. Purpose: show how one primary pair can produce many oranges, greens and violets through proportion.

Mixture	Proportion	Result
Red + Yellow	equal	
Red + Yellow	more red	
Red + Yellow	more yellow	

Colour mixing experiment
Copy the table above into your sketchbook. Fill in the Result column for each proportion. Then repeat the whole table with **Yellow + Blue** and with **Blue + Red**.

mixing table — oranges, greens, violets

Think
How many different greens can you make? How many violets? How many oranges?

Colour contamination
Unwanted colours can appear when your brush or palette is dirty. A little red in yellow can make yellow less bright. This is not always a problem — sometimes artists deliberately create muted colours. Know whether the change was intentional or accidental.

Studio tip
Keep separate mixing areas clean and wash your brush properly between colours.

[7.2.5] Complementary colours

Complementary colours are pairs opposite one another on a traditional colour wheel:

RED ↔ GREEN · BLUE ↔ ORANGE · YELLOW ↔ VIOLET

When placed next to each other, they create strong visual contrast and can make both colours appear more intense.

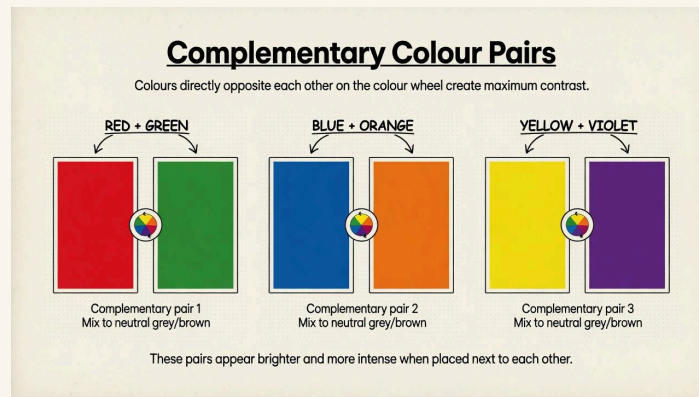


IMAGE 7.2.08 — Complementary pairs. Purpose: show the three classic complementary contrasts clearly.

Artists use complementary colours to: attract attention · create energy · make a focal point · increase contrast · create visual vibration · emphasise light · create depth.

Look at art: Van Gogh and complementary contrast

Van Gogh frequently used complementary relationships. Blue and orange create powerful contrast. A warm orange beside a cool blue makes the difference much more noticeable.

Ask yourself

Where is the strongest contrast? Does it create a focal point? Would the painting feel the same without the complementary colours?

Complementary colour collage

Choose one pair: red+green · blue+orange · yellow+violet. Create a collage using only your pair + white + black (+ optional neutral grey). Think about balance.

complementary collage

Challenge

Create a small composition where complementary contrast leads the viewer's eye towards one specific area.

Did you know?

When complementary colours are ****mixed**** together, they generally reduce each other's intensity — useful for neutrals and muted colours. So complementary colours have two effects: ****next to each other → strong contrast****; ****mixed together → reduced intensity****.

[7.2.6] Colour study from artists

Artists develop personal palettes — the selection of colours used in an artwork. Some use many colours; others work with a very limited palette. Studying another artist's palette helps you understand colour decisions.

How to analyse an artist's colour palette

1. What are the dominant colours (largest areas)?
2. What are the accent colours (small but attention-grabbing)?
3. Is the palette warm or cool?
4. Highly saturated or muted?
5. Are there complementary contrasts?
6. Are the colours realistic?
7. What mood do they create?



IMAGE 7.2.10 — Artist colour-palette analysis. Purpose: show artwork beside extracted swatches so students can analyse dominant and accent colours.

Practical task — Artist colour study

Choose one artwork from an artist studied in this unit. Create a small colour study focused on colour relationships rather than copying every detail.

1. Identify about 5–8 important colours.
2. Mix those colours using paint.
3. Create colour swatches.
4. Paint a small study of part of the artwork.
5. Reflect: The most important colour relationship is... / I noticed... / When I mixed the colours I discovered... / The colour choice I found most interesting was...

swatches

[7.2.7] Abstract colour study

Abstract art does not necessarily attempt to represent objects realistically. An artist may focus on colour, shape, line, texture, movement, composition, rhythm or emotion. Abstract art can be completely non-representational, or it can simplify and distort recognisable subjects.

Monochromatic colour

A monochromatic artwork uses variations of one main hue. A blue monochromatic work might contain pale blue, medium blue, dark blue, grey-blue, blue-green, blue-violet — considerable variety within one colour family.

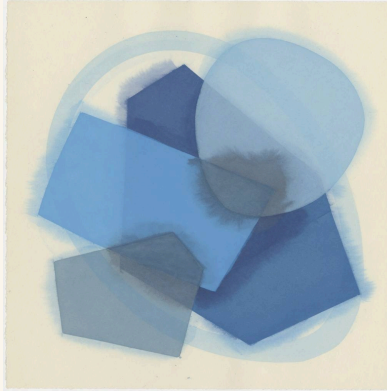


IMAGE 7.2.11 — Monochromatic blue study. Purpose: show variety within one hue through value and saturation.

Task — One colour, many possibilities

Choose one hue (for example BLUE). Create an abstract composition using only variations of that hue. You may change value, saturation, shape, scale, texture, direction, repetition. Keep the main colour family dominant.

Think about composition: Where should the viewer look first? Which shape is largest? Where is the darkest colour? Where is empty space? How can repetition create rhythm?

monochromatic abstract composition

Artist focus — Mark Rothko

Mark Rothko is associated with Colour Field painting, in which large areas of colour become the central focus. His paintings may appear simple at first, but look carefully for subtle changes in colour, soft edges, relationships between fields, differences in value and intensity, and the effect of one colour on another. Rothko wanted viewers to experience colour rather than simply identify it.



IMAGE 7.2.12 — Teaching study after Rothko. Purpose: show soft-edged colour fields and subtle relationships. Not a museum reproduction.

Look closely

Spend one minute looking. Do not describe a subject — there may be none. Describe what your eyes do, where you feel visual tension, which colour advances or recedes, whether colours feel heavy or light, whether edges feel sharp or soft.



IMAGE 7.2.13 — Three thumbnail compositions. Purpose: show that composition and colour mood are tested before the final piece.

Final project — Abstract colour composition

Create a final abstract colour artwork based on one option:

****A — Mood:**** communicate an emotion through colour.

****B — Monochrome:**** one colour family.

****C — Complementary:**** one complementary pair.

****D — Artist inspired:**** take inspiration from an artist in this unit, then develop your own composition.

****Development process:****

1. Idea — three possible concepts
2. Thumbnails — at least three small compositions
3. Colour tests — experiment with palette separately
4. Select — choose strongest; explain why
5. Develop — final artwork
6. Refine — check palette clarity, variation, focal point, balance, mood, clean mixes
7. Reflect — write about your decisions

thumbnails + colour tests

final abstract colour artwork

Common mistakes

Mistake	Better thinking
"Lots of colours = colourful"	Success is about relationships, not quantity
Everything mixed until brown	Mix deliberately; keep mixtures organised
Colours look dull	Check clean brush, palette contamination, too many mixes, too much complementary
"Doesn't look like the artist"	Colour study is about understanding decisions, not a perfect copy

[7.2.8] Review and project completion

What have I learned?

I can...

- ☐ identify primary colours
- ☐ mix secondary colours
- ☐ identify tertiary colours
- ☐ explain hue, value and saturation
- ☐ create tints and shades
- ☐ explain complementary colours
- ☐ use complementary contrast
- ☐ describe how colour can affect mood
- ☐ identify a limited colour palette
- ☐ create a monochromatic composition
- ☐ analyse an artist's use of colour
- ☐ develop my own colour palette
- ☐ explain my colour choices

Artists to remember

Artist	Key ideas
Vincent van Gogh	expressive colour, complementary contrast, movement
Henri Matisse	intense colour, non-naturalistic colour, harmony and contrast
Wassily Kandinsky	colour and emotion, abstraction, colour and shape
Mark Rothko	colour fields, large areas of colour, subtle relationships

Key vocabulary

Term	Meaning
Colour wheel	a diagram showing relationships between colours
Primary colour	a starting colour for traditional paint mixing: red, yellow, blue
Secondary colour	made by mixing two primary colours
Tertiary colour	made by mixing a primary with a neighbouring secondary
Hue	the basic identity or colour family
Value	the lightness or darkness of a colour
Saturation	the intensity or purity of a colour
Tint	a colour made lighter, traditionally by adding white
Shade	a colour made darker, traditionally by adding black
Complementary colours	colours opposite each other on the traditional colour wheel
Palette	the range or selection of colours used by an artist
Warm colours	generally associated with red, orange and yellow
Cool colours	generally associated with blue, green and violet
Monochromatic	using variations of one main hue
Contrast	a noticeable difference between visual elements
Harmony	a pleasing or coherent relationship between visual elements
Abstract	art that simplifies, transforms or does not directly represent the visible world

Pedagogical note

This unit is practical. The aim is not to memorise colour theory — it is to **see** a colour relationship, **name** it, **reproduce** it, **experiment** with it, and finally **use** it intentionally in your own work.

Final reflection

The colour relationship I understand best is... _____

The artist who influenced me most was... _____

The most surprising thing I discovered about colour was... _____

The colour experiment that worked best was... _____

One thing I would change in my final artwork is... _____

Next time I use colour, I will... _____

Unit 7.3 - Looking at Artists' Work

Unit 7.3 — Looking at Artists' Work

Art is not only about making.

Artists also look, research, question, compare, interpret and respond.

When we study an artist's work, we are not trying to find a single "correct" answer about what the artwork means. Instead, we learn to look carefully and build interpretations using visual evidence.

In this unit you will learn how to: observe an artwork carefully · describe what you can see · identify visual elements and techniques · interpret possible meanings · use art vocabulary · compare different artworks · research an artist · make a practical response · present your ideas clearly · develop your own creative response.

An important rule for this unit is:

Look first. Interpret second.

Before saying what an artwork means, make sure you can explain what you can actually see.

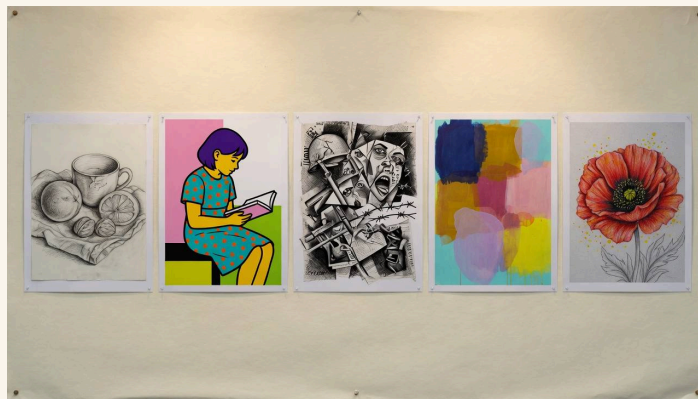


IMAGE 7.3.01 — Many ways of making. Purpose: show that artworks can look very different and invite different ways of looking.

Looking at artists

Artist images in this unit are **teaching illustrations** inspired by each artist's approach (not museum reproductions). Famous paintings may still be in copyright; study licensed images with your teacher when needed.

[7.3.1] Introduction to contextual analysis

What is contextual analysis?

Contextual analysis means looking at an artwork while considering the circumstances surrounding it. These may include: who made it · when and where it was made · what was happening at the time · the artist's experiences · materials and techniques · the intended audience · cultural influences · the purpose of the artwork.

Context can help us understand an artwork, but knowing the artist's biography does not automatically tell us what an artwork means. The artwork itself is always an important starting point.

How to look at an artwork

A useful way to analyse an artwork is to move through four stages:

LOOK → DESCRIBE → ANALYSE → INTERPRET

Stage	Question
Look	What can you see?
Describe	What visual elements are present?
Analyse	How has the artist used those elements?
Interpret	What might the artwork communicate or make the viewer think or feel?

Stage 1 — Look

Before interpreting, spend time simply looking. Do not immediately search for the artist's name or read the wall label.

Ask yourself: What is the first thing I notice? What colours, shapes and lines can I see? Is it realistic or abstract? What materials might have been used? Is the surface smooth or textured? What is happening? Where does my eye go next?

Stage 2 — Describe

Description means saying what you can actually see without explaining what it means.

- Description: "The artwork contains three figures standing in front of a large blue background."
- Interpretation: "The figures look lonely because the artist wanted to show isolation."

The second statement might be reasonable — but you need evidence before making it.

Fact or interpretation?

	Statement	Type
A	"There are two people in the painting."	Description
B	"The people appear to be looking at each other."	Observation
C	"They are arguing."	Interpretation
D	"The artist wanted to show conflict."	Interpretation
E	"The figures are painted in dark colours."	Description
F	"The dark colours create a threatening atmosphere."	Analysis / interpretation

There is nothing wrong with interpretation. The important thing is to distinguish between what you see and what you think it might mean.

Think

Rewrite statement C so that it stays closer to observation, then add a separate interpretation sentence that uses visual evidence.

Stage 3 — Analyse

Analysis asks: How has the artist created this effect?

Instead of "The painting feels dramatic," try: "The artist creates a dramatic effect through strong contrasts between dark shadows and bright areas of colour." Now you have used visual evidence.

Stage 4 — Interpret

Interpretation asks: What might the artwork mean? There may be several possible interpretations.

Useful phrases: "This could suggest..." · "The artist may be exploring..." · "The use of ___ might represent..." · "This makes me think about..." · "One possible interpretation is..." · "The artwork could be understood as..."

These phrases remind us that interpretation is often open to discussion.

The visual elements

Remember from Unit 7.1: LINE · SHAPE · FORM · TEXTURE · COLOUR · COMPOSITION

Element	Ask
Line	What types of lines are used?
Shape	Geometric or organic?
Form	Illusion of three-dimensional form?
Texture	Can you see or feel texture?
Colour	What colours dominate?
Composition	How are the elements arranged?

Other things to look for

Idea	Look for
Scale	How large or small are things in relation to one another?
Space	Crowded or empty? Foreground, middle ground, background?
Contrast	Light/dark · warm/cool · large/small · rough/smooth · detailed/simple
Emphasis	What does the artist want you to notice first?
Movement	Does your eye move through the artwork? How?
Rhythm	Are colours, shapes or lines repeated?
Balance	Does the composition feel stable or unstable?

LOOKING BOARD — label what you can see

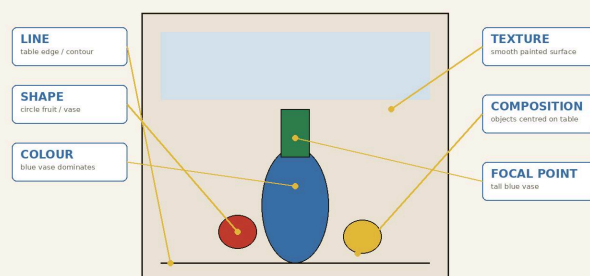


IMAGE 7.3.02 — Annotated looking board. Purpose: show how to label line, shape, colour, texture, composition and focal point on one artwork.

A simple analysis framework

When you are stuck, use these six questions:

1. WHAT? What can I see?
2. HOW? How has the artist made it?
3. WHERE? Where does my eye go?
4. WHY? Why might the artist have made these choices?
5. WHAT DOES IT MEAN? What could the artwork communicate?
6. HOW DOES IT MAKE ME FEEL? What is my personal response?

Your turn — six questions

Choose any artwork in this unit. Answer all six questions using short notes.

six-question analysis notes

Look at art — Pablo Picasso

Teaching focus: Guernica (1937)

Picasso's Guernica is one of the most famous paintings of the twentieth century. At first glance it can seem confusing: distorted figures, animals, sharp shapes and dramatic gestures.

Instead of beginning with "This painting is about war," try looking more carefully.



IMAGE 7.3.03 — Teaching study after Picasso's Guernica. Purpose: show distorted forms, strong contrast and a restricted palette. Not a museum reproduction.

Look

What figures can you identify? What animals can you see? Which shapes are most noticeable? What colours are used? Where are the darkest areas? Are the forms realistic?

Analyse: Picasso uses distorted forms · strong contrasts · fragmented shapes · dramatic gestures · a restricted black, white and grey palette.

Interpret: These choices can contribute to a disturbing and dramatic atmosphere. The artwork was created in response to the bombing of the Spanish town of Guernica during the Spanish Civil War. Context helps us understand why the subject and visual language are so powerful.



IMAGE 7.3.04 — Guernica details for close looking. Purpose: practise describing small sections before interpreting the whole.

[7.3.2] Compare and contrast artworks

Artists can approach similar subjects in completely different ways.

Compare and contrast means identifying both similarities (what the artworks have in common) and differences (how they differ).

How to compare artworks

Do not simply write: "Artwork A is blue and Artwork B is red."

Go further — explain what the difference does:

"Artwork A uses predominantly cool blue and green colours, creating a quieter atmosphere, while Artwork B uses warm reds and oranges, making the composition feel more energetic."

This connects visual evidence → effect.

Comparison vocabulary

both · similarly · likewise · whereas · however · in contrast · unlike · while · compared with · on the other hand

Example: "Both artists use simplified shapes. However, Matisse creates a sense of movement through flowing organic forms, whereas Picasso uses fragmented geometric shapes."

Compare these two artworks

Look at teaching studies inspired by Matisse's *The Dance* and Picasso's *Les Femmes d'Alger*. You could compare: colour · line · shape · human figures · space · composition · realism · distortion · mood.

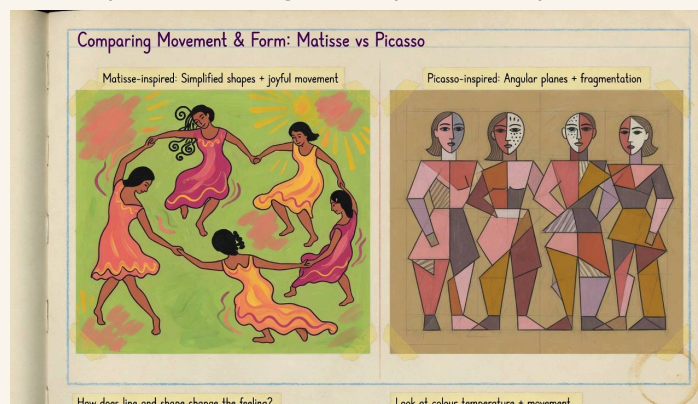


IMAGE 7.3.05 — Compare Matisse and Picasso. Purpose: same broad subject (figures) with very different visual languages.

Questions

What do both artworks have in common? How are the figures represented differently? Which uses more naturalistic space? How does colour affect the mood? Which artist uses more simplified shapes? Which artwork do you prefer? Why?

Practical task — Compare & contrast

Choose two artworks. Create a page divided into three sections:

Artwork A — five observations · **Both** — three similarities · **Artwork B** — five observations.

Then write a short paragraph beginning **Both artworks...** and another beginning **However...**

compare & contrast page

[7.3.3] Artist transcription

What is an artist transcription?

An artist transcription is a practical study based on an existing artwork. The purpose is not to make a perfect copy. You are trying to understand how the artist worked — colour, brushwork, composition, line, texture, shape, materials, technique.

By recreating a small section, you begin to understand decisions that are difficult to notice simply by looking.

Why do artists study other artists?

Artists have always learned from other artists. Studying an artwork can help you discover new techniques, materials, ways of composing, colour combinations, ways of representing subjects, and new ideas.

Studying an artist does not mean copying their work and claiming it as your own. The purpose is to learn and develop your own visual language.

How to make a transcription

1. Choose — select an artwork with a technique you want to understand.
2. Observe — look closely at one small section.
3. Analyse — identify colours, shapes, lines, textures, materials, brushstrokes.
4. Recreate — make your own study of the section.
5. Reflect — "I noticed..." / "I found it difficult to..." / "I learned that..." / "This technique could be useful in my own work because..."



IMAGE 7.3.06 — Transcription beside original detail. Purpose: show learning by remaking a section, not copying a whole artwork.

Artist transcription task

Choose a small section of an artwork. Do not copy the entire artwork. Enlarge the section so it fills about half a page. Try to reproduce the colours, marks, textures and local composition. Place your transcription next to the original (or a print).

Compare: What did you discover by making the study that you did not notice before?

enlarged section transcription

[7.3.4] Artist research**Why research artists?**

Research helps you understand an artist's background, influences, techniques, ideas, development and historical context. Good research is more than collecting facts — find information that helps you understand the artwork.

What should you research?

Area	Ask / record
Basic information	full name · date of birth · country · profession
Artistic practice	What did they make? Materials? Techniques? Subjects?
Style	What does their work look like? Which visual elements matter?
Context	When did they work? What was happening? Any art movement?
Important works	Choose two or three artworks
Your response	What interests you about this artist?

Art movements

An art movement is a group of artists or a period in which artists share certain ideas, approaches or visual characteristics. Examples: Impressionism · Cubism · Surrealism · Expressionism · Pop Art · Abstract Expressionism.

Artists do not always fit neatly into one category. An artist may change style throughout their career or be influenced by several movements.

Research skills

When researching online, do not copy entire paragraphs.

READ → understand · SELECT → choose what is relevant · PARAPHRASE → write in your own words · RECORD → keep track of sources · CHECK → compare more than one reliable source when possible.

Did you know?

When you use an artwork in your research, record: ****artist · title · date · medium · source of the image****.

Example: Pablo Picasso, **Guernica**, 1937, oil on canvas.

If you use an image from a website, your teacher may also ask you to record the website or museum collection.

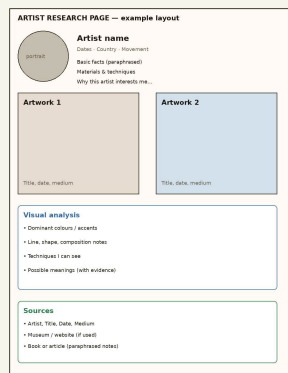


IMAGE 7.3.07 — Example artist research page. Purpose: show organised portrait, artworks, biography notes, visual analysis and sources.

Build a research page

Create one research page for an artist studied in this unit. Include basic facts, style notes, two artworks, one contextual fact, your personal interest, and sources.

artist research page

[7.3.5] Presentation skills

Why presentation matters

Being able to communicate your ideas clearly is an important part of Art & Design. A strong presentation does not need lots of text. It should be: organised · readable · visually interesting · informative · easy to follow.

What makes a good art presentation?

Element	Aim
Title	Make the artist's name clear
Images	Use good-quality images of artworks
Information	Select important facts — do not fill the slide with text
Visual analysis	Show that you can look at and discuss the artwork
Personal response	Explain what interests you

Presentation structure

A simple artist presentation could have six slides:

1. Artist name + portrait + short introduction
2. Biography and context
3. Important artwork #1
4. Important artwork #2
5. Visual analysis + techniques
6. Personal response + what you learned

PRESENTATION LAYOUT

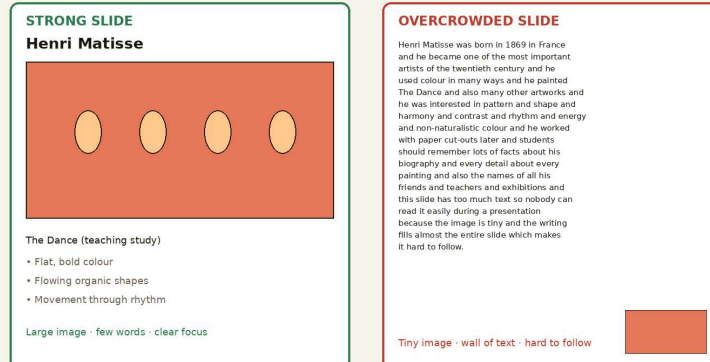


IMAGE 7.3.08 — Strong slide vs overcrowded slide. Purpose: show that clear layout and large images beat walls of text.

Presentation task

Prepare a **3–5 minute** presentation about an artist. You should: introduce the artist · show at least two artworks · explain visual characteristics · discuss techniques · explain some contextual information · include your own response.

Remember: do not simply read your slides. Use the slides to support what you are saying.

Presentation checklist

- ☐ Can everyone read my text?
- ☐ Are my images large enough?
- ☐ Have I avoided copying large amounts of text?
- ☐ Can I explain the artworks in my own words?
- ☐ Have I used art vocabulary?
- ☐ Have I included my personal response?
- ☐ Do I know what I am going to say?
- ☐ Have I checked the pronunciation of the artist's name?

[7.3.6] Personal response to artists**What is a personal response?**

A personal response is your own creative reaction to an artist's work. It is not a copy.

You might borrow: a technique · a colour palette · a composition · a way of simplifying shapes · a type of mark-making · an idea · a method of working — then combine that influence with your own subject and ideas.

Influence is not copying

Imagine you study Van Gogh and notice his expressive brushstrokes. You decide to use energetic brushstrokes in a painting of your own neighbourhood. That is a personal response: you learned from the artist and applied it to your own subject.



IMAGE 7.3.09 — Influence without copying. Purpose: show an original student response beside the artist approach that inspired it.

Personal response task

Choose one artist from your research. Identify one characteristic that interests you (for example: "I like the way Matisse uses flat areas of colour"). Create an **original** artwork using that characteristic.

Your artwork must: be your own idea · show a clear connection to the artist · demonstrate experimentation · include a written explanation of your choices.

Development page

Before the final response, create a development page:

Section	Include
Artist influence	What did you learn from the artist?
Experiments	Try at least three different approaches
Changes	What did you change?
Final idea	Which experiment will you develop?
Why?	Explain your choice

Example

- Artist: Henri Matisse
- What interests me: strong, flat areas of colour
- Subject: my school playground
- Experiment 1: realistic colours
- Experiment 2: exaggerated colours inspired by Matisse
- Experiment 3: simplify the playground into large colour shapes
- Final decision: combine experiments 2 and 3

This is how artist research becomes your own artwork.

development page — influence · experiments · final idea

Artist focus — Georgia O'Keeffe

Georgia O'Keeffe is useful for understanding how an artist can transform an ordinary subject through scale, cropping, colour and simplification.

Flowers appear frequently in her work, but she does not always show them as small objects surrounded by empty space. Instead, she often enlarges them dramatically. The viewer is invited to look at the flower in a completely different way.



IMAGE 7.3.10 — O'Keeffe idea: flower + photograph. Purpose: show transformation through scale, cropping and simplification.

Look closely

How much of the flower can you see? Is the whole flower visible? What happens when the subject becomes extremely large? How does cropping affect the composition? What happens to the flower's shapes when they are enlarged?

Personal response — enlarge an ordinary object

Choose an ordinary natural object (leaf, shell, stone, flower, seed, bark). Create an artwork in which the object is much larger than it would normally appear.

[7.3.7] Review and project completion

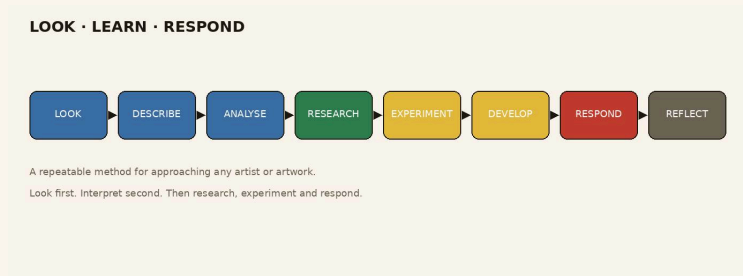


IMAGE 7.3.11 — Looking method flowchart. Purpose: give a repeatable method for approaching any artist or artwork.

Artwork analysis checklist

When analysing an artwork, I can...

- ☐ describe what I see
- ☐ identify visual elements
- ☐ discuss colour
- ☐ discuss line and shape
- ☐ discuss texture
- ☐ discuss composition
- ☐ identify techniques
- ☐ use visual evidence
- ☐ distinguish observation from interpretation
- ☐ suggest possible meanings
- ☐ explain my personal response

Artist research checklist

I can...

- ☐ find reliable information
- ☐ identify important artworks
- ☐ describe an artist's style
- ☐ explain relevant context
- ☐ use appropriate art vocabulary
- ☐ record my sources
- ☐ paraphrase information
- ☐ select useful images

Personal response checklist

I can...

- ☐ identify something that interests me about an artist
- ☐ experiment with the artist's techniques
- ☐ develop my own ideas
- ☐ avoid simply copying the original
- ☐ explain the connection between my work and the artist
- ☐ reflect on what I learned

Self-assessment

The artwork I found most interesting was... _____

I was interested in it because... _____

The visual element I noticed most was... _____

One technique I learned was... _____

Something I found difficult was... _____

The artist influenced my own work by... _____

In my personal response, I changed... _____

If I developed this project further, I would... _____

Key vocabulary

Term	Meaning
Analysis	careful examination of how an artwork has been made and how its elements work together
Context	the circumstances surrounding an artwork, including historical, cultural and social background
Description	explaining what can be seen without interpreting its meaning
Interpretation	an explanation of what an artwork might communicate or mean
Visual evidence	specific features of an artwork used to support an observation or interpretation
Composition	the arrangement of visual elements within an artwork
Contrast	a strong difference between visual elements
Emphasis	the way an artist makes something attract attention
Focal point	the area that attracts the viewer's attention
Scale	the size of something in relation to another object or to the artwork
Cropping	deliberately cutting or excluding part of an image
Style	the characteristic visual qualities of an artist or period
Technique	a particular method or skill used to make an artwork
Medium	the material or materials used to create an artwork
Movement	a group of artists who share certain artistic ideas or approaches
Transcription	a practical study made from an existing artwork to investigate the artist's methods
Influence	something that affects an artist's ideas, methods or visual language
Personal response	an original creative or written reaction to an artist or artwork

Final challenge — Look, learn, respond

Choose one artwork studied in this unit.

1. ****Look**** — two minutes observing without writing
2. ****Describe**** — five things you can see
3. ****Analyse**** — at least three visual decisions
4. ****Interpret**** — two possible interpretations
5. ****Research**** — artist and context
6. ****Transcribe**** — a small practical study
7. ****Respond**** — your own artwork inspired by one aspect
8. ****Reflect**** — What did I learn from this artist that I can use in my own Art & Design practice?

Unit 7.4 - Pattern and Texture

Unit 7.4 — Pattern and Texture

Pattern and texture are everywhere.

Look around the classroom and you will find patterns in: fabrics · tiles · floors · wallpaper · books · packaging · clothing · architecture · plants · shells · animal skins · natural surfaces.

Artists and designers use pattern and texture to make surfaces more interesting, create rhythm, organise compositions and communicate ideas.

In this unit you will learn how to: observe and describe texture · develop a vocabulary for surfaces · create texture through mark-making · enlarge small details · create relief and printed textures · develop repeated patterns · use symmetry and repetition · combine pattern and colour · develop a limited colour palette · transform observations into original designs.

A key idea throughout this unit is:

Texture describes a surface. Pattern organises repetition.

Sometimes they work separately. Very often, they work together.

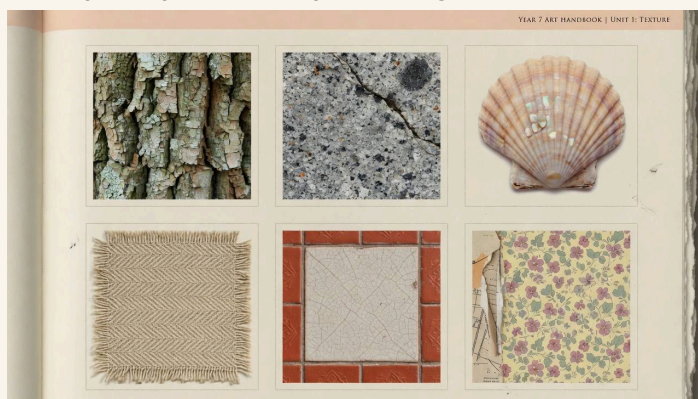


IMAGE 7.4.01 — Texture everywhere. Purpose: show natural and man-made surfaces side by side as sources for looking and designing.

Looking at designers

Designer and artist images in this unit are **teaching illustrations** inspired by each designer's approach (not museum or commercial reproductions). Study licensed images with your teacher when needed.

[7.4.1] Introduction to texture

What is texture?

Texture is the surface quality of something. When we touch an object, we can feel its physical texture. When we look at a photograph or drawing, we may see or imagine the texture even though we cannot touch it.

Type	Meaning	Examples
Actual texture	texture that physically exists and can be felt	rough bark · smooth glass · soft fabric · bumpy stone · ridged cardboard · woven material
Visual texture	texture represented visually as an illusion	hundreds of small marks that look like fur on smooth paper

Texture in the natural world

Nature is an excellent source of texture. Look at: tree bark · stones · shells · leaves · feathers · flowers · sand · wood · moss · animal fur · scales.

Natural surfaces are rarely completely uniform. A stone may contain cracks, spots, lines, holes, colour variations, and rough and smooth areas. An artist can observe these details and transform them into visual marks.

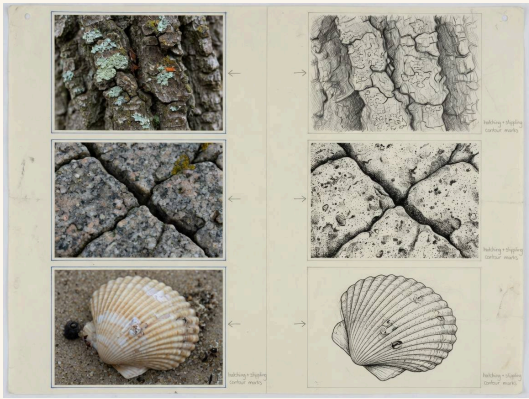


IMAGE 7.4.02 — Natural texture and drawn response. Purpose: show photographic surface details beside mark-based drawings that interpret them.

Texture vocabulary

Before you can draw texture, learn how to describe it.

Word	Meaning
Rough	uneven or coarse
Smooth	few noticeable irregularities
Soft	pleasant, flexible or gentle to touch
Hard	solid and resistant
Shiny	reflects a lot of light
Matte	little or no strong reflection
Bumpy	many small raised areas
Ridged	raised lines or bands
Grainy	small particles or irregular marks
Cracked	lines or breaks
Fibrous	made of fibres (wood, rope, some fabrics)
Scaly	overlapping scale-like shapes
Furry	covered with fine hairs

Look, touch, describe

Choose three objects. Observe and, where appropriate, touch them. For each object complete:
It looks... · It feels... · I can see... · The surface is... · The marks I would need to draw it are...
This last question matters: you are translating physical experience into visual language.

three objects — look · touch · describe

[7.4.2] Mark-making techniques

What is mark-making?

Mark-making is creating different marks on a surface. A mark can be: a line · a dot · a scratch · a smudge · a brushstroke · a repeated shape · a scribble · a cross · a spot · a patch of tone.

Different marks can communicate different surfaces and qualities.

Marks and materials

Tool	Try
Pencil	light/dark lines · hatching · cross-hatching · dots · shading · smudging
Pen	precise lines · dots · repeated marks · cross-hatching · stippling
Charcoal	broad marks · soft areas · dark tones · smudged surfaces · expressive marks
Paintbrush	thin lines · thick strokes · dry-brush · dots · washes
Sponge	irregular patches · broken textures · repeated marks
Card / other tools	scraping · printing · dragging · stamping

Key techniques

Technique	How it works	Useful for
Hatching	parallel lines — close, far, straight, curved, thick or thin	tone; denser lines often look darker
Cross-hatching	one set of lines over another at different angles	darker tones · shadows · rough / complex surfaces
Stippling	dots; closer dots can look darker	stone · sand · skin · particles · shadows
Scribbling	controlled scribble; direction matters	hair · grass · fur · tangled branches · rough surfaces
Contour marks	marks that follow the direction of a form	making a rounded stone feel three-dimensional

MARK-MAKING LIBRARY

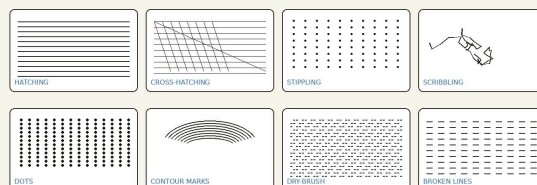


IMAGE 7.4.03 — Mark-making library sheet. Purpose: show hatching, cross-hatching, stippling, scribbling, dots, contour and dry-brush clearly.

Task — Mark-making library

Create a page with at least ****20 different marks****. Use pencil, pen, charcoal, paint and any other available tools. Do not try to make pictures — explore the marks themselves.

Under each mark, write one word: sharp · soft · rough · energetic · delicate · heavy · broken · smooth · irregular · repetitive

20+ mark library with descriptive words

Texture challenge

Choose five textures: bark · stone · fabric · metal · water. For each, create a small drawing using ****only marks****. Do not draw the object itself — make the viewer recognise the surface from the marks alone.

Reflect: Which texture was easiest to communicate? Which was most difficult? Why?

five texture-only mark studies

[7.4.3] Texture enlargement

Sometimes an artist discovers interesting patterns by looking at a very small part of a larger object.

From a distance you see a shell. Close up you may see: lines · curves · cracks · ridges · repeated shapes · colour variations. The smaller detail can become an artwork in itself.

The viewfinder

A viewfinder is a simple frame used to isolate a small section of something. It helps artists decide what to include and what to leave out.

A viewfinder can be made from card, paper, two L-shaped pieces of card, or a cardboard frame.

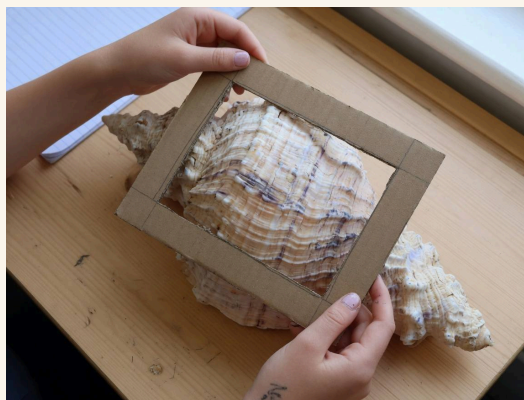


IMAGE 7.4.04 — Viewfinder selecting a detail. Purpose: show how framing isolates an interesting section of a textured object.

Task — Texture viewfinder

Choose a textured object (bark, shell, stone, leaf, fabric, wall, metal). Place your viewfinder over it. Move the frame until you find an interesting section. Draw **only** what is inside the frame — not the whole object.

Try three viewpoints:

- **Study A** — small area
- **Study B** — different section
- **Study C** — extremely close-up

Compare them. Which is the most visually interesting?

three viewfinder studies A · B · C

From object to abstraction

When you enlarge a small detail enough, the viewer may no longer recognise the original object.

- A shell might become: curves + lines + shapes
- Bark might become: vertical lines + cracks + irregular shapes
- A stone might become: spots + patches + tonal areas

This is one way observation can lead to abstraction.

[7.4.4] Relief and printmaking**What is relief?**

A relief is a surface in which some areas are raised and others remain lower. Relief can be low, high, shallow or deep. You encounter it in embossed paper, coins, carved surfaces, decorative architecture and textured packaging.

Texture and collage

A collage can contain different materials with different textures. Try combining: paper · cardboard · tissue · fabric · string · corrugated card · leaves · textured papers.

Materials do not have to stay in their original form. You can: tear · cut · fold · crumple · layer · overlap · roll · twist.

Printmaking

Printmaking transfers an image or texture from one surface onto another. For Year 7 we explore simple relief printing: the raised areas receive ink or paint and transfer the image onto paper.

You can create a simple printing surface using foam, cardboard, textured materials, string, leaves or cut shapes. Apply a small amount of paint or printing ink to the raised surface. Press paper onto it. Lift carefully. The result is a print.

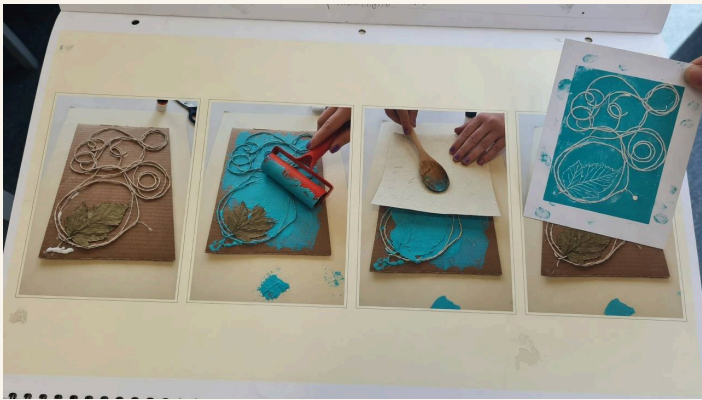


IMAGE 7.4.05 — Relief print process. Purpose: show plate → ink → paper → final print as a clear sequence.

Task — Texture print
Create a printing plate using at least **three different textures**. Make a **series** of prints. Experiment with pressure, amount of paint, direction, overlapping, rotation and repetition.
Do not make only one print. The first print is an experiment.

printing plate + series of texture prints

Positive and negative areas in print

Term	Meaning
Positive	the area that creates the printed mark
Negative	the area around or between the marks

The relationship between positive and negative areas can create pattern and rhythm.

[7.4.5] Pattern development

What is pattern?

A pattern is a repeated visual element or arrangement. Patterns can be made using shapes, lines, colours, textures, symbols, images or natural forms. Patterns can be regular or irregular.

Where do we find pattern?

Area	Examples
Nature	leaves · petals · shells · feathers · animal markings · honeycombs
Culture	textiles · ceramics · architecture · tiles · carpets · wallpaper
Design	clothing · packaging · stationery · websites · interiors

Motif

A motif is a repeated visual element used to create a pattern. A designer might create one simple flower shape — that flower becomes the motif. It can then be repeated, rotated, or changed in size and colour. One motif can produce many different patterns.

Repetition, rhythm and symmetry

Idea	Meaning
Repetition	using an element more than once — creates rhythm, unity, movement, consistency. You can change size, direction, colour or spacing.
Rhythm	visual movement created when elements are repeated so the eye moves through the composition — can feel slow, fast, regular, irregular, energetic or calm
Symmetry	parts of a design correspond to one another (e.g. a butterfly). This unit mainly explores bilateral symmetry and repeated symmetrical arrangements.
Radial symmetry	elements arranged around a central point — flowers, some shells, snowflakes, sunflowers

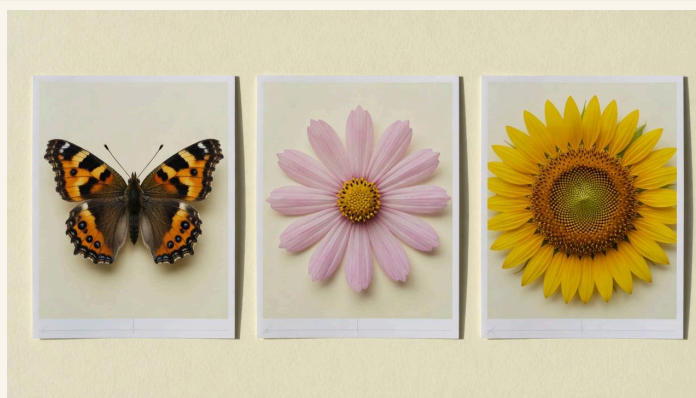


IMAGE 7.4.06 — Symmetry in nature. Purpose: show bilateral and radial organisation as sources for pattern thinking.

Task — Create a motif

Choose something from nature (leaf, shell, flower, feather, insect, stone). Simplify it into a small motif. Do not include too much detail. Create a design that can be repeated.

****Develop four versions:****

1. Original motif
2. Simplified motif
3. Geometric version
4. Abstract version

Which one works best as a repeated design?

Task — Repeat the motif

Take your favourite motif. Create four pattern arrangements:

| Arrangement | Method |

| ---|---|

| ****A — Grid**** | repeat horizontally and vertically |

| ****B — Alternating**** | change the direction of every second motif |

| ****C — Rotation**** | rotate the motif around a central point |

| ****D — Overlapping**** | allow the motifs to overlap |

Compare the results.

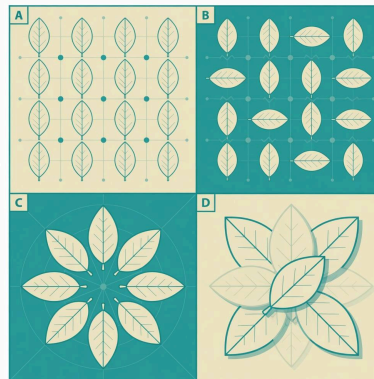


IMAGE 7.4.07 — One motif, four arrangements. Purpose: show grid, alternating, rotation and overlapping from the same motif.

Pattern and negative space

A pattern is not only about the marks. The spaces between them — negative space — also matter.

- Motifs close together → dense · busy · energetic
- More space between motifs → calm · open · light

[7.4.6] Colour in pattern design

Colour can completely change the character of a pattern. The same pattern can look calm in blue and green, energetic in orange and red, dramatic in black and yellow, or delicate in pale pink and cream. Pattern and colour should be considered together.

Limited palette

A limited palette uses a small number of colours — for example blue + white + dark blue, or red + orange + cream + black. Fewer colours can make a pattern feel more unified and easier to read.

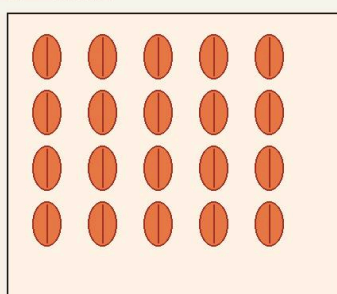
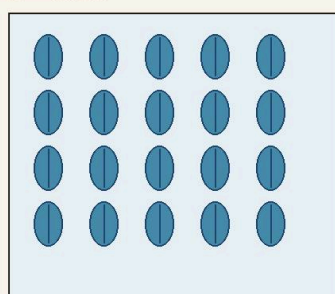
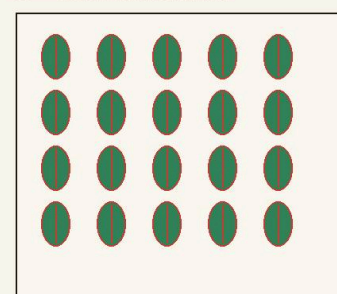
ONE PATTERN · THREE PALETTES**A — WARM****B — COOL****C — COMPLEMENTARY**

IMAGE 7.4.08 — One pattern, three palettes. Purpose: keep the pattern identical while changing only the colours.

Task — One pattern, three palettes

Take one of your patterns. Create three colour versions:

- **Palette A** — warm colours
- **Palette B** — cool colours
- **Palette C** — complementary colours

Keep the pattern exactly the same. Only change the colours.

Reflect: Which has the strongest visual impact? Which feels most harmonious? Which would work best as a textile or wallpaper design? Why?

same pattern · three colour palettes

Look at design — William Morris

William Morris was a British designer and artist associated with the Arts and Crafts movement. He is particularly well known for decorative textile and wallpaper designs inspired by nature. His patterns often contain leaves, flowers, birds, stems, repeating forms and harmonious colours.



IMAGE 7.4.09 — Teaching study after William Morris. Purpose: show how natural motifs organise into a repeating decorative design. Not a commercial reproduction.

Questions

Can you identify the individual motifs? Where does one motif end and another begin? How are the motifs repeated? Are they all facing the same direction? How much negative space is visible? Which colours dominate? Does the pattern feel regular or organic?

Look at design — M.C. Escher

M.C. Escher explored repetition, symmetry and tessellation — a pattern of shapes that fits together without gaps or overlaps. He often transformed simple shapes into recognisable forms such as birds, fish, lizards or insects. Pattern can become much more than decoration; it can become a visual puzzle.

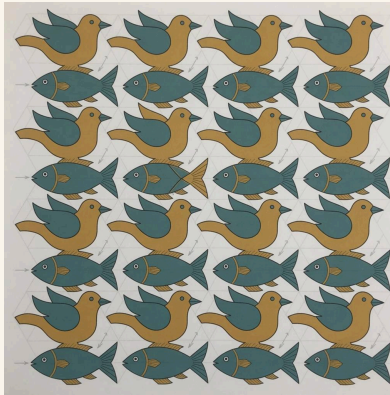


IMAGE 7.4.10 — Teaching study after Escher tessellation. Purpose: show repeated shapes transforming into recognisable figures. Not a museum reproduction.

Tiling and tessellation

A tessellation covers a surface using repeated shapes. Examples include floor tiles, bathroom tiles, Islamic geometric decoration and honeycomb structures.

Challenge — Simple tessellation

Create a simple geometric shape that can be repeated without leaving gaps. Try triangles, squares or hexagons. Then change the shape slightly. Can you turn the repeated shape into something recognisable?

tessellation experiment

[7.4.7] Final project — Pattern and texture design

Project brief

Create an original pattern inspired by texture or natural forms. Your final design should show: observation · texture · a clear motif · repetition · pattern development · thoughtful colour choices · composition.

FROM TEXTURE TO PATTERN



Pattern is a design process that begins with observation and develops through transformation.

IMAGE 7.4.11 — From nature to design. Purpose: show the full transformation sequence students should follow.

Development process

- 1. Observe — choose a source (shell / leaf / bark / stone / flower / feather). Make observational studies.
- 2. Texture studies — at least three different surface studies using different mark-making techniques.
- 3. Enlarge — use a viewfinder; create an enlarged study.
- 4. Create a motif — transform part of your observation into a simplified motif.
- 5. Experiment with repetition — at least four arrangements (grid · alternating · rotation · overlapping).
- 6. Experiment with colour — at least three colour tests (warm/cool · complementary · monochromatic · limited palette).
- 7. Final design — select the strongest combination of motif + repetition + composition + colour.

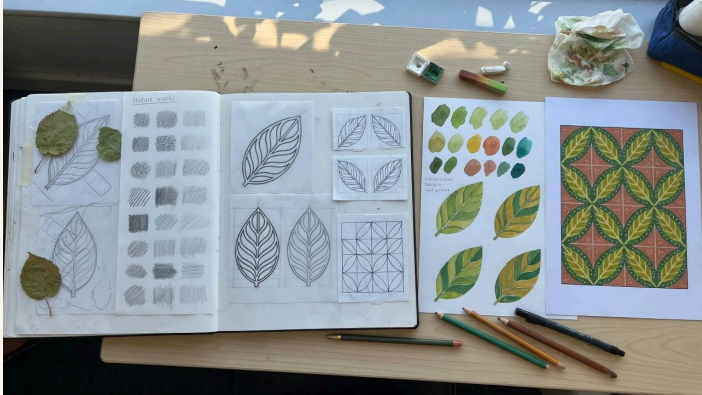


IMAGE 7.4.12 — Student development page. Purpose: model observation → texture → motif → pattern → colour → final design.



IMAGE 7.4.13 — Final pattern beside source. Purpose: show a strong Year 7 design next to the natural object that inspired it.

development page + final pattern design

Common mistakes

Mistake	Better thinking
"I repeated the same picture."	Change direction, scale, spacing, colour or overlap so repetition creates relationships.
"My pattern is too busy."	Look at negative space — more space between motifs may help.
"My motif has too much detail."	Simplify — a good motif stays recognisable when repeated.
"My texture looks like random lines."	Look again: direction? repetition? concentration? change across the surface?
"My colours don't work together."	Reduce the number of colours — a limited palette creates stronger unity.

Pattern design in everyday life

Pattern is not only decorative. Designers use pattern in clothing, wallpaper, packaging, ceramics, book covers, stationery, websites, architecture, interiors and product design.

A successful pattern must often work across a large surface. A fabric design may need to repeat 10, 100 or thousands of times — so the designer must think about how the individual motif behaves when repeated.

Final review — I can...

- ☐ explain what texture is
- ☐ distinguish actual and visual texture
- ☐ use different mark-making techniques
- ☐ describe surfaces using appropriate vocabulary
- ☐ observe natural textures
- ☐ use a viewfinder to isolate details
- ☐ enlarge a texture
- ☐ create a relief surface
- ☐ make a simple print
- ☐ explain what a pattern is
- ☐ create a motif
- ☐ use repetition
- ☐ create rhythm
- ☐ use symmetry
- ☐ experiment with positive and negative space
- ☐ develop a limited colour palette
- ☐ create an original pattern

Reflection

The texture I found most interesting was... _____

The mark-making technique I found most effective was... _____

I discovered that texture can be created by... _____

My favourite motif was... _____

The pattern arrangement that worked best was... _____

Colour changed my pattern by... _____

The most successful part of my final design was... _____

If I developed this project further, I would... _____

Key vocabulary

PRIME SCHOOL PRESS

Art & Design

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Every child is an artist. Keep the studio open.

Year 7 art and design develops making, looking and thinking: drawing, colour, print, 3D and the artists who changed how we see.

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- Skills: drawing, paint, print, 3D
- Artists and movements in context
- Sketchbook habit and portfolio building
- Critique language and reflection
- Final project per unit

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